# Master of the Universe

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/25881799.

**Rating:**
General Audiences

**Archive Warning:**
No Archive Warnings Apply

**Category:**
Gen

**Fandoms:**
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018), He-Man and the Masters of the Universe

**Relationships:**
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Entrapta/Hordak (She-Ra), Mermista/Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra), George/Lance (She-Ra), Kyle/Lonnie/Rogelio (She-Ra)

**Characters:**
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**Language:**
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**Series:**
Part 3 of Honor & Power

**Stats:**
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by inkpenavenger

Summary

It's been a year or so since Adora found her birth family on the distant world of Eterina. When her brother Adam is a no-show for Bow and Glimmer's wedding, Adora starts to get worried. That worry proves justified, as Adam's nemesis Skeletor launches an attack on both their worlds in his ultimate plan to conquer the universe...

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Sequel to Secrets of the Sword

Now complete!

# Chapter 1

The big day was here at long last. Brightmoon was abuzz with activity. Guests from all over Etheria and even a few other planets crowded the castle grounds. Queen Glimmer looked out from the balcony of her room at the excited crowd below. The peculiar mix of excitement and nervousness thrummed within her. She ran her fingers through her new, even shorter haircut. She was so lost in her own head that she didn't hear the door open, and started when a hand touched her shoulder.

"Sorry!" said Catra. "You didn't answer when I called, so…"

"Yeah sorry," Glimmer sighed. "I was just distracted."

"Obviously," Catra replied with a smirk. "It's almost time. Excited?"

Catra was wearing the formal outfit Adora had commissioned for her from the Brightmoon tailors. Adora wasn't normally big on anything fashion related, but she'd been unusually specific in her instructions. Catra wore dark brown pants with a red jacket not dissimilar to the one Adora often wore. A white half cape with gold trim was draped over one shoulder, and, most notable, a pair of simple leather boots. Her hair was up in a messy ponytail.

"Yeah," Glimmer said, looking at her hands. "And nervous."

"Nervous?" Catra said, taking a seat on the windowsill. "Why nervous? You're just marrying your best friend today."

"I… I don't know. I mean, I know things won't really *change* between me and Bow," said Glimmer. "We'll be the same people in the same relationship tomorrow that we were yesterday. It's just… it is a big deal though, isn't it? Getting married?"

"I guess so…" Catra said, looking out over the castle grounds.

A silent moment passed.

“So,” Glimmer said, nudging her friend, “you and Adora gonna be next?”

“What?” Catra said with a start. “I mean… all this,” she gestured at the crowd below, “seems a little much, but…”

“But?”

“But… I mean, yeah. I guess. Eventually."

"You and Adora don't have to have something this big," Glimmer said. " *I* wouldn't want something this big of it weren't for, y'know, being the queen and all. And Bow's dads." They both chuckled at that. There was a knock at the door.

“Yes?” said Glimmer.

The door opened, and in stepped King Micah, wearing a set of fine purple robes.

“Am I interrupting?” he asked.

“No,” Catra said, sliding off the windowsill. “I was just checking in on her too. I’m gonna go find Adora and make sure Bow isn’t panicking either.” She laughed as she made her way out the door, which she closed behind her.

“You look *beautiful* , babygirl,” Micah said, once they were alone.

“ *Dad* ,” Glimmer chided. “I’m not even in my wedding dress yet.”

“And?” he walked over and enveloped his daughter in a warm hug. When they parted, Glimmer saw tears in his eyes.

“You ok, Dad?” she asked.

“Yeah,” Micah said, wiping the tears away. “Just… remembering how your mother looked on our wedding day.”

Glimmer hugged her father again.

“I’m missing her a lot today, too,” she said.

“She’d be so proud of you,” Micah said.

“I know,” Glimmer replied with a smile.

“All right,” said Micah, at last releasing Glimmer from the hug. “I’m going to go make sure Casta’s not pulling her hair out over last-minute preparations. See you soon.”

“Love you, Dad,” Glimmer said.

“Love you too, babygirl.”

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Bow paced the room anxiously in a white and gold suit with pink and purple trim, and of course, a bare midriff.. Adora was at a loss to figure out anything to say to alleviate his nerves. There was a knock at the door, and Catra peeked in.

“How’s it going?” she said with a laugh. “Arrow-Boy’s not gonna make a break for it, is he? You confiscated his arrows, right?”

Adora in her plain but elegant and flowing white dress, gave Catra a strained smile, and nodded toward the pacing Bow. Catra sighed and approached him. She put her hands on his shoulders and made him stop pacing.

“Bow!” she said. “ *What* are you so nervous for? You are marrying the love of your life today, so get it together.”

“It’s not that,” Bow said. “Marrying Glimmer? It’s a dream come true, what worries me is…”

“Is what?”

“...How am I gonna be king? I’m just some library school dropout with a bunch of silly trick arrows! I can’t be a king! What if I screw it up? What if the people reject me and start a revolution?

What if I accidentally ruin everything? ‘There goes King Bow, destroyer of Etheria!’ I can’t do this!”

“Bow, breathe," Catra said sternly. She held his gaze as she continued. "First of all, you and Glimmer have been making decisions together forever; literally nothing is changing. Second,” Catra smirked, “I’m your Royal Advisor, so it’s literally *my job* to make sure you two *don’t* mess everything up. And today, that includes your wedding.”

Bow closed his eyes and took a few deep breaths. The tension seemed to gradually leave his shoulders.

“Thanks, Catra,” he said at last.

“Alright,” Catra said. “Now you finish getting ready, I’m going to take Adora; there’s more things I need to check on.”

“Ok,” Bow said. “I’ll see you guys in a bit.”

Catra took Adora’s hand and led her out of the room.

“Ok,” Adora said. “I guess we’re going.”

Catra led her briskly down a few corridors.

“Catra,” Adora asked, “where exactly are we going?”

Suddenly, Catra stopped, pulled Adora close, and kissed her.

“Wow, what was that for?” Adora said.

“Do I need a reason?” Catra smirked.

“I guess not,” Adora replied, giving her another quick kiss. “You look amazing, by the way.”

“Well I hope you’d think so,” Catra said. “I mean, you picked the outfit.”

Adora smiled.

“You look beautiful, too,” Catra said with a slight blush.

“Thank you,” Adora said. Another kiss.

“Have Adam and the others shown up yet?” Catra asked.

“No,” Adora said with a slight frown. “And if they don’t get here soon, they’re going to be late. I wonder if I have time to run to the portal beacon and give him a call…”

“You do if you can beat me there!” Catra said, suddenly taking off down the hall.

“Hey! No fair! I’m in a dress!” Adora cried, hiking up the hem and rushing after Catra.

“And I’m wearing shoes!” Catra called back. “Even.”

They were both giggling uncontrollably by the time they reached the beacon chamber. The guard stationed at the door rolled their eyes as the two of them caught their breath and entered the room. Adora approached the softly humming device and punched in the commands to contact the beacon on Eternia. The system buzzed several times as the call waited to be answered, but no one picked up.

“Why is no one answering?” Adroa said, frustrated.

“Maybe something came up,” said Catra. “Like an emergency or something. Adam wouldn’t miss the wedding if it wasn’t something important.”

“Then maybe we should-”

“No!” Catra interrupted. “One, if Adam’s in trouble serious enough that he needs us, he’d have called, even today. Two, there is no way *you* are missing our best friends’ wedding too.”

“Look at you, being the reasonable one today,” Adora mocked.

“Somebody has to be,” Catra said. “You can be the reasonable one if *I* freak out on *our* wedding day, ok?”

“‘Our wedding day?’” Adora repeated with a cocked eyebrow.

“Ah… I mean, y’know,” Catra stammered. “Whenever… that is…”

Adora smiled and took Catra’s hand.

“C’mon,” she said. “Now *we’re* going to be late.”

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The throne room was utterly packed with people. A flowering vine archway stood in front of the thrones, courtesy of Perfuma, and Frosta had conjured drifting snowflakes above the crowd that made the whole room sparkle. Adora and Catra stood to either side of the archway, awaiting the beginning of the ceremony. Spinnerella was at the center, having been asked to officiate. Adora’s eyes scanned the crowd seeing so many familiar faces. There was Mermista, failing to look nonplussed by the over-the-top romantic atmosphere, with Sea Hawk practically twinkling beside her. Scorpia was already crying, Perfuma holding her pincer. Frosta was peeking out into the central aisle, unable to see over everyone else standing. Adora saw Micah and Castaspella; Entrapta, Wrong Hordak, and Hordak were in the back; Bow's dads, Lance and George stood with their twelve other sons; even Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio were there. There was Swift Wind, and Netossa, and Huntara. A trace of frustration tinged with worry tugged at Adora’s mind as she saw that Adam and Teela were still nowhere to be seen.

Music began to play, drawing Adora's attention back to the moment at hand. Murmuring in the room fell silent as the music continued. With a flash of pink light, Glimmer teleported into the throne room in front of the flower arch. Her wedding gown was predominantly purple with gold trim. A gossamer white cape trailed behind her, stitched with a lace-like feather pattern to resemble her mother's wings.

At the other end of the room, the great gold double doors swung slowly open, and Bow walked through them, looking resplendent in his suit with the usual bright red heart-shape emblazoned on the chest. Glimmer beamed as he walked toward her. Bow's dads could be heard sobbing over the music. Bow reached the front of the room and took Glimmer's hands in his own. Adora noticed Catra staring at her from across the way, the latter blushing slightly and turning her attention back to the ceremony about to begin. Adora smiled and did likewise.

The music and whispers of the crowd of guests faded, and Spinnerella said, "Let's begin…"

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Later, at the reception, the mood was utterly jubilant. The grounds outside the castle proper swarmed with people. The music was loud, the food was plenty, and the dancing was energetic. Adora and Catra had just sat down for a break from dancing, catching their breath and getting a drink, when Wrong Hordak (his hair gold and his eyes and teeth bright pink) pulled Hordak awkwardly onto the dance floor to the laughter of many and the delighted squeal of Entrapta. Adora scanned the crowd again, still finding no sign of her brother.

"He *still* isn't here?" Catra said. "Now *I'm* getting worried." She sighed. "Look, let's find Bow and Glimmer and let them know we have to go. We'll get changed and hop a portal to Eternia. I swear, if he just *forgot* , I'm gonna kill him."

Adora and Catra stood from their table and moved through the crowd hand in hand. After pushing past dozens of people, Adora finally caught sight of the newlyweds.

"Adora! Catra!" Glimmer cried as they approached. "This is so amazing! I've *never* seen the grounds so crowded. Aunt Casta really outdid herself, didn't she?"

“It’s great,” Adora said. “We’ve been having a great time. But listen, Adam still hasn’t shown up…”

“What!?” Bow said.

“I’m sure something came up, but I’ve tried calling him on the beacon several times and no one is answering, so… I’m just getting worried. Catra and I are going to pop over to Eternia just to make sure everything’s ok.”

“Do you want us to come with you?” Glimmer asked.

“No! No, you guys just enjoy the party,” Adora insisted. “I’m sure everything’s fine. We’ll probably be back before you know it.”

“The big dope probably just forgot the date,” Catra added.

Suddenly, there was a loud bang, a flash of light, and a rush of wind. The four of them looked toward the commotion. People were scattering away from the dance floor as there was- a portal! A bright swirl of energy wreathed the opening across space. Then a dozen or so figures in shiny black armor poured through the gateway which slammed shut behind them.

“What the-” Catra cried.

Another flash, another bang, another dozen figures marched into sight, firing blasters above the crowd which began to scream and scatter. Hordak grabbed one and slammed it to the ground as it aimed a blaster at Entrapta. He ripped the arm off and stomped on the head, sparks and smoke pouring out.

“These are Prime’s designs,” Hordak said, attacking and demolishing another bot. “How? Where are they coming from?”

Indeed, the figures swarming onto the Brightmoon grounds through portal after portal did resemble the ones employed by the Galactic Horde, albeit with a glossy black paint job and red lighting instead of green.

“We have to hold them off,” Adora called. “Get everyone to safety!”

Catra was already kicking off her boots. Glimmer vanished, then reappeared a second later holding Bow’s bow and quiver. Adora summoned her sword.

“For the Honor of Grayskull!”

The grounds were in chaos. Civilians screaming and trying to flee. Dozens of portals opening and disgorging squads of black-armored bots. The castle guards and princesses fighting off the bots to cover the civilians’ escape. Glimmer teleported all around, blasting bots and teleporting guests far away to safety.

Catra leaped onto a bot and ripped into it with her claws. She sprang from that one as it fell toward another, colliding with its chest and knocking it prone. As she tore that one apart too, she noticed an embossed mark on the chestplate. The mark was the same color as the rest of the armor, so it didn’t stand out at a distance. It was a skull with a familiar pattern of lines and shapes engraved in it. Adora had tried to teach Catra how to read First Ones writing over the last year or so, and she knew enough to recognize what this said.

“No,” she breathed. Then shouting, “Adora! The mark! On the bots’ chests!”

Adora, who’d just blasted a group of bots emerging from yet another portal, grabbed another bot by the head. She crushed its head in her fist, cut it in half at the waist with her sword, then held up the chestpiece for a closer look. She saw the skull and the writing that said-

“Skeletor,” Adora said. “Adam!”

Bow disabled another bot with a shock arrow, then happened to glance up. His heart sank at the sight.

“Uh...Adora!” he called pointing up.

Adora looked into the night sky. There weren't just portals on the ground. They were also opening in the air, starfighters rocketing through them, dark silhouettes against the multiple moons. Adora called out for Swift Wind, leaping onto his back and soaring into the sky to try and stem the flow.

"How is this happening?" Bow said, fighting back to back with Catra.

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"Administrator access granted."

A secret chamber at the heart of Grayskull opened. Two dozen soldiers streamed in to line sides of the room. Skeletor, clad in black armor and purple robes, strode briskly across the long walkway, punctuating every few steps with a resonating strike of his staff on the crystalline floor. Behind him followed his second-in-command, the green-skinned sorceress Evil-lyn. At last, Skeletor arrived at the far end of the chamber, standing before a great crystal throne. Beside the throne was a pedestal, a dock for a singular device he still required. Behind the throne, the great sealed iris that formed the crux of this, his ultimate design.

"Report, Evil-lyn," he barked. "Speak!"

"The city is surrounded, the castle sealed off," Evil-lyn began. "And the attack on Etheria commences as we speak."

"And He-Man?"

"He continues to fight with the Royal Guard that resists us. I assure you, we will have him before moonrise."

"I want him kneeling at my feet."

"After all this time," Evil-lyn mused. "Grayskull is ours."

"No!" Skeletor shouted. He turned and sat down on the throne grasping his staff in one hand and the locksmith's device, the one

that had made all this possible at long last, in his other. “Mine.”

# Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adam was running late. He'd *completely* forgotten that today was the big day until Teela showed up at his door in formal attire. She wore a sleeveless white top with flowing pants, her hair in elaborate braids.

"Why are you dressed like that?" he'd yawned, rubbing sleep from his eyes.

"Are you serious?" Teela had said.

"What?"

"Bow and Glimmer's wedding!" she'd cried. "You were supposed to meet me in the portal room ten minutes ago!"

Adam had let out a shocked cry that woke up Cringer and sent him sprinting around the room in a panic. By the time they stopped him and got him calmed down, Adam's room looked like there'd been a tornado. Then Adam spent a frantic twenty minutes getting cleaned up and dressed. He was hopping down the hall on one foot, trying to lace up his other boot on the way to the portal beacon chamber.

"I can't *believe* you forgot," Teela said.

"I said I'm sorry," Adam protested. "And I didn't exactly *forget* , I just overslept!"

"Just hurry up. We might still make it in time for the ceremony if we leave-"

She was cut off by a distant boom that reverberated in the castle floor.

“What was that?” said Adam.

“It almost sounded like…”

Another distant thud, this one stronger. Just then, the guards who watched over the beacon chamber rushe toward them from around the corner.

“Captain Teela, Your Highness,” one of them shouted. “The city is under attack!”

“Skeletor?” Adam asked. “Of course he’d pick *today* of all days.”

“Your highness,” the guard said. “We must get you to safety. Report is, Skeletor’s forces are already inside the city!”

“Inside?” Teela demanded. “How?”

“I don’t know, Captain,” the guard replied. “There was no word of anything approaching. It’s like they just appeared out of thin air inside the walls.”

“I’ll get the prince to safety,” Teela said. “You two go help defend the castle.”

The guards nodded and raced off.

“The sword is back in my room,” Adam whispered once they were gone. “I didn’t plan on needing it today.”

“Then let’s hurry,” Teela replied, and they dashed off back toward Adam’s room.

They were halted by a flash of light and a bang of displaced air. A swirling ring of light filled the corridor, a powerful wind blowing out of it.

“What is that?” Adam cried over the din.

Just as suddenly, the light disappeared with a crack… and half a dozen figures in shiny black armor stood in the corridor before

them. It looked like the armor Skeletor's soldiers wore, but the body shape was wrong. A person couldn't fit inside that- And they were firing!

Teela grabbed Adam's arms and pulled him behind her, throwing up a shield spell just in time. After deflecting a barrage of blaster bolts, Teela flung the shield forward, knocking the attackers off balance, then followed up with an offensive spell blast. The armored figures were thrown backward and smashed into the wall, sparks spewing from their joints as they came apart.

"Machines," Adam said. "They're bots!"

"Where did Skeletor get a bunch of bots?" Teela wondered. "And more importantly, how did he open a portal into the castle?"

Another distant explosion shook the stone floor beneath their feet.

"Questions for later," Adam said. "Right now, sword."

Again, the two raced off toward Adam's room. It was still a mess from before, and Cringer was cowering under the bed (despite there not actually being enough room under there for him), but Adam was easily able to retrieve the sword from its hiding place behind his headboard.

"No…" Teela breathed. She was standing at the windowed doors to the balcony off Adam's room, staring outside. Adam moved beside her and looked out as well. His jaw fell open.

The city was in flames. Thick columns of smoke rose in every direction. In the streets below, people ran in panic from blocks of shiny black bots as they marched through the city. There were so many. Where did Skeletor get a force this large? And they were opening portals directly into the city *and* into the castle- Then it dawned on him.

"Mom!" Adam suddenly shouted. "Dad!"

"What-" Teela began.

“He’s opening portals *into the castle* .”

“Oh no!”

Adam held up his sword.

“By the Power of Grayskull!”

Magical energy crackled from the crystalline blade as Adam transformed into He-Man. He raced back out into the hallway, Teela sprinting along after him. They encountered a few groups of bots along the way, but quickly dispatched them. Soon, they turned the corner into the passage outside the throne room… and Adam's heart sank. More than a dozen green-armored Royal Guards lay unconscious up and down the hall. Among those fallen was one with a yellow sash…

"Dad!" Teela cried. She rushed to Duncan's side as Adam ran past them and into the throne room.

Adam had just a moment to take the sight in. His parents in shackles, surrounded by bots. A portal opening, and his father shoved through. His mother looked back toward the door, fear in her eyes.

“Mom!” Adam cried, sprinting toward her as fast as he could.

The queen’s eyes locked with his and went wide for a moment before she, too, was pushed through the portal. The bots followed, and a moment later, the doorway was gone.

“No!” cried Adam, reaching the spot where the portal had been, barely a second too late. He turned back to Teela, who was helping Duncan back to his feet. “Duncan,” Adam said, “what happened?”

“I...I’m not sure,” he said groggily, rubbing his head. “There was a flash of light, and then those bots were just everywhere. There were so many…”

“Skeletor must have taken them to Snake Mountain,” Adam said. We have to go. Now.”

“Right,” Duncan said. He tried to step away from Teela, but was unsteady on his feet, catching himself on the wall.

“Dad, just slow down,” Teela said. “You’re in no shape to go running off to Snake Mountain right this second.”

“I’m the sworn Man-at-Arms of the Royal Guard. It’s my duty to protect the Royal Family,” Duncan grumbled.

“We need a plan,” Teela said. She looked at Adam. “And Adora.”

“Right,” Adam said. “First stop, the portal beacon.”

As they made their way through the castle toward the portal chamber, another explosion rocked the building. When they caught their balance and the dust began to clear, they saw that the corridor ahead had collapsed. Adam punched the wall, growling in frustration, his fist driving effortlessly into the stone.

"Come on," Duncan said. "We can cut around the exterior and get to the beacon from there."

Quickly, the three found their way outside the castle and began making their way around to another entrance. Adam's thoughts raced as he tried to tune out the sounds of battle, screams, and destruction from the city below. They'd nearly reached the castle's front entrance when the sky above went dark. Black clouds had appeared suddenly, and they shifted and formed the image of a massive skull, filling the evening sky. Skeletor's voice, thundering across the kingdom, the sound and image enormous enough to be seen and heard across the land.

"People of Eternia," the voice boomed. "The war is over! My forces are victorious. Greyskull is mine, and your king and queen are my prisoners there."

Adam's blood ran cold.

"Let this be my first decree," the voice continued. "Those who do not pledge themselves to me shall be destroyed. The new age begins."

The clouds lost their distinct shapes and slowly dissipated. Adam transformed back into himself as he fell to his knees, the Sword of Power clattering to the ground beside him. Teela was saying something, but Adam couldn't hear. His heart was in his stomach, his head swimming, his ears ringing.

Skeletor had his parents.

Skeletor had Grayskull.

Adam had failed.

Chapter End Notes

> Sorry for the long gap between chapters. Life get in the way and sometimes you lose the writing bug that powered you through 18k words of your lasr story for a while. Lol
>
> Thanks for waiting, and thanks for reading. Hoping to get back to this more regularly in the future.

# Chapter 3

Swift Wind weaved between the starfighters streaming out of portals into Etheria's night sky. On his back, She-Ra swung her sword side to side, cleaving through the hulls of the ships with ease, sending them hurtling to the ground in smoking pieces. Yet there were still more! It seemed like for every one She-Ra destroyed, two more appeared.

"This isn't working," Swift Wind said to her. "There's too many of them!"

"We have to take out as many as we can," Adora replied, shearing the nose off a ship as they passed by. She raised the sword straight up over her head as they flew under another ship which exploded in midair as it came apart.

Another portal opened directly in front of them, and Swift Wind barely managed to roll to the side in time to avoid colliding with it. Then a barrage of laser cannon blasts barely missed them.

"Maybe you're right, Swifty" Adora said. "Let's get back to the others and make a plan."

"Good idea," he replied and dove back down toward the ground.

In the castle courtyard below, Adora could see a cluster of her friends, back to back, fighting off a surrounding horde of Skeletor's bots. Scorpia blasted bots with volleys of her red lightning as Perfuma crushed and tore apart bots with her vines. Bow fired arrow after arrow into the oncoming enemies while Glimmer blasted them with magical attacks. Frosta kept calling up ice barricades to provide cover while Micah and Castaspella conjured magical shields to block incoming laser fire. Catra and Hordak made quick work of any bots that made it through the onslaught with their bare hands.

“Everybody down!” Adora cried as she leaped down from Swift Wind’s back.

She landed in the center of the group just as they all ducked low to the ground. Adora glowed brightly, then swung her sword horizontally in a full circle, letting out a battle cry as well as a powerful blast of magic in all directions. Most of the bots in the courtyard were reduced to smoking scrap. A moment later, s Swifty landed beside the group.

“Maybe lead with that move next time, princess,” Catra said with a smirk.

“Is everyone ok?” Adora asked.

“We’re good,” Glimmer said. “All the guests got out.”

“We need a plan,” Bow said. He looked around as more portals opened around them.

“Well, we can’t just keep fighting these bots head on,” Catra said. “We need to stop them at the source. We need to get to Eternia and stop Skeletor from sending more.”

“Ok,” Glimmer said. “You and Adora get to the portal beacon and go. We’ll stay here and protect Etheria.”

“Hordak,” Bow said. “Do you think you and Entrapta could come up with a killswitch for these bots? Something to take them out in large numbers?”

Hordak surveyed the destroyed bots all around them. He found one that was mostly intact and picked it up. “Yes,” he said.

“Alright,” Glimmer said. “Then let’s get Entrapta, and I’ll teleport you both to your lab in Dryll.”

“I’ll go with them too,” Scorpia chimed in. “I’ll watch your back while you work.”

“Are you sure we should, y’know, split up like this?” Adora said. She didn't like the idea of leaving Etheria with it under attack.

"Isn't it obvious?" Catra said. "Skeletor's making a *big* move. Maybe even going after Greyskull. He's attacking Etheria to keep *you* occupied. To try and stop you from backing Adam up."

"We'll be ok, Adora," Bow said. "If you can help Adam stop Skeletor, it'll end the attack at its source."

"And besides," Glimmer added, "it's not like this is the first alien invasion we've fought off."

"Heck of a wedding day…" Bow said.

"But somehow, it's *so* us," Glimmer replied with a wink. "Good luck!"

With that, Glimmer grabbed ahold of Scorpia and Hordak and teleported away.

Adora and Catra each gave Bow a hug in turn.

"Be safe," Adora said. She and Catra started toward the castle.

"And, uh, congratulations?" Catra called back over her shoulder.

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As much as they both hated any delay, Catra and Adora also didn’t think it wise to go off to fight a battle on Eternia in formal attire. So after a quick detour to their room to change, they raced to the portal beacon chamber and punched in the coordinates for Eternia. A shimmering doorway appeared, and they stepped through.

The first thing they noticed was the distant sounds of laser fire and explosions. Even this deep inside the castle, Catra could smell smoke. The portal closed behind them as they stepped out into the hallway. Almost immediately, they spotted three figures

rounding the corner. It was Teela. Her father had an arm around her shoulder and was leaning on her, clearly injured. Behind them, shoulders slumped and head hanging, was Adam.

“Adam!” Adora cried as she raced toward him.

“Adora?” he looked up, embracing her as she approached.

“We were just on our way to come call you,” Teela said. “Skeletor, he-”

“We know,” Catra interrupted. “He’s attacking Etheria too.”

“What?” Duncan exclaimed. “How?”

“Somehow he’s opening portals just wherever he wants,” Adora said. “Hundreds of bots just showed up out of nowhere.”

“Adora,” Adam said, his voice strained. “He has mom and dad. And he has Greyskull.”

Adora’s eyes went wide, and a lump rose in her throat.

“Then we go after them,” Catra said, stepping up and putting a hand on Adora’s shoulder. “First priority. We get them out, then we deal with Skeletor.”

“I need to find more guards,” Duncan said. “Coordinate evacuation and resistance.”

“Dad, you’re in no condition to fight,” Teel said.

“Hold on,” Adora said. She stepped over to Duncan and placed a hand on his chest. She closed her eyes, then began to glow with golden light. The light poured into Duncan, and he inhaled sharply.

The light subsided, and Duncan was able to take his weight off Teela.

“Thanks,” he said. “You four go after the king and queen. I’ll coordinate the defenses here.”

“Be careful, dad,” Teela said. “I love you.”

“I love you, too, Teela,” Duncan replied. He kissed the top of his daughter’s head and set off into the castle.

“Come on,” Adam said. “We’re probably better off sneaking out of the city on foot. Those ships flying around would spot us easily if we try to take a skiff.”

=======

A tense hour later, the four of them had nearly made it to the outer wall of the city. Rather than trying to slip through a gate, Catra had suggested they make their way to a section of wall that had been destroyed in the attack and sneak through there. Along the way, they’d managed to slip past several patrols of bots. Adam had thus far been relieved to see no sign of any civilians hurt or captured. Hopefully, everyone had managed to flee to safety.

Catra was peeking out from an alley, watching a squad of bots rounding a corner, ready to signal the group to dart across the last street toward the hole in the wall, when Adam heard a distant voice.

“No!,” it cried. “Oh no, unhand me! Help! He-Man! Help!”

Adam looked at the others.

"We can't," Teela said. "If those bots spot us, we'll get overrun and we'll never make it to Grayskull."

Adora saw the pleading look in her brother's eyes. She understood how he must feel, because she'd felt the same way so many times. She looked to Catra.

"There has to be *something* we can do," she said. "We can't just leave them…"

Catra considered a moment.

"Ok," she said. "Let's get closer and see if we can help. If there's not too many bots, we can surprise them and rescue whoever that is calling for help."

Adora smiled. Adam looked relieved.

"But *don't* transform," Catra added. "If they don't see He-Man or She-Ra, maybe they won't call for backup right away."

Everyone nodded. They rushed toward the sound of the pleading voice, keeping low and trying to move as quietly and possible. They reached an intersection in the roads and peered around the corner. There in the street were two bots, struggling with what appeared to be a small being trapped in a metallic net. The struggling figure squirmed so violently that the bots seemed to be having difficulty lifting them into a balanced position to be carried. The cries for help were coming from the net.

"Ok, there's only two of them," Catra whispered. "We hit them fast and save whoever's in that net. No swords; no muscles, got it?"

Everyone nodded. Catra gave the word, and the four charged into the street. Catra was fastest, bounding forward on all fours, and leaped onto the shoulders of one of the bots. Her claws made short work of separating its head from its body. Teela cast a spell ensnaring the legs of the other bot and pulling them out from under it. Adora rushed in and stomped hard on its head, shattering it into countless tiny pieces. Adam had already reached the dropped net and opened it, releasing its captive.

He was approximately half their height with long pointed ears and a pointed nose. His hair was wild and bright orange, sticking out in all directions on top of his head and down the sides of his face. He wore simple dark green clothes and had a bulky metallic device slung on his back with a leather strap.

"Oh!" the diminutive being squeaked. "A thousand blessings on you for saving me!"

"Who are you?" Adora asked.

"I am Gwildor of Thenor," he said. "Locksmith and engineer extraordinaire. Have… you heard of me?"

"Can't that I have, I'm afraid," Adam said. "I have heard of Thenor, though."

Gwildor seemed to actually look up and focus on Adam for the first time.

"Well of course you have," he said brightly. "It's an honor to meet you, Prince Adam."

"We need to move," Adora said. "More bots could show up any minute. We need to be out of the city before they do."

"I can't leave already," Gwildor protested. "I just arrived, and I have *vital* information for He-Man about Skeletor's attack. Your highness, surely you know how I can find He-Man."

"Actually, you're in luck," Adam began.

"Adam!" Teela interrupted.

"Teela, none of that matters now," Adam replied. He turned back to Gwildor. "I'm He-Man."

"Oh!" Gwildor cried. "Well of course you are! Who else *would* the fates entrust the protection of Eternia to than its prince."

"We have to go," Catra said insistently.

"Yes, yes," Gwildor said. "Now that I've found you, let's find a safe place to hide so I can explain."

Together, Adora, Adam, Teela, Catra, and Gwildor made their way back to and through the collapsed section of the city wall and

slipped out.

=======

They'd found a small cave in a shallow ravine a couple miles outside the city. It gave them good cover from the air and the ground; bots or soldiers would be unlikely to notice the entrance unless they walked directly by it.

"Alright," said Teela. "So why was it so important that you find He-Man?"

"Because of this," Gwildor said. He removed the device from his back and set it on the cave floor between everyone.

It was roughly cylindrical, eighteen inches in length with about a six inch diameter. Most of the black surface was covered in hundreds of tiny brass buttons, with one larger red button near the base. The top section tapered in slightly and was crowned with a dozen or so slender forked rods that were silver in color.

"I call it the Cosmic Key," Gwilder began. "It's the most unique key in the universe, able to unlock a door to virtually anywhere."

"The portals," Adora breathed.

" *You* created the device Skeletor is using to attack our worlds?" Catra demanded.

"Well, yes, but I didn't *mean* to," Gwildor said. "He kidnapped me! Held me prisoner for an entire year. Forced me to study and refine a portal-making device he already had."

"A beacon," Adam said. "Adora, a portal beacon!"

"He must have stolen one from your ship when he took it last year," Teela added.

"Wait," Adora said. "Where did you get this Key, then? Portals were still opening in the city when we left."

“I finished the first Key months ago,” Gwildor said. “But instead of releasing me, they *still* kept me locked up at Snake Mountain in case it malfunctioned or needed repairing. I knew whatever Skeletor had planned with that Key would be terrible beyond imagination. So I secretly built a second Key and used it to escape this morning.”

“How does it work?” Catra asked. “Entrapta and Hordak’s portal beacons need to connect with another beacon to open a doorway. How do these Keys open a portal just anywhere?”

“It’s all down to the tones,” Gwildor said, his eyes suddenly twinkling with excitement. “Everything in the universe is connected, so if you create the right resonances you can bring two parts of space into sync and open a doorway between them. It's all very complicated, what with the algorithms and failsafes to prevent accidentally opening a door into empty space or the middle of a sun."

"Can this Key open a portal into Grayskull?" Adam asked.

"Of course," Gwildor replied. "Those were the first coordinates Skeletor made me calculate."

"So let's go," Adam said. "We use the key to get to and inside of Grayskull without being spotted."

"Oh, but we can't!" Gwildor exclaimed.

"Why not?" asked Teela.

"Both Keys are attuned to vibrational patterns of the fabric of space," he explained. "If one Key is activated, it resonates with the other. Skeletor would know I activated it."

"Gwildor, we don't have a choice," Adora said. "The king and queen - our parents - are being held prisoner there by Skeletor."

"And Grayskull contains the most dangerous information in the universe," Catra added. "We have to stop Skeletor before he

finishes whatever he has planned."

"We have to risk it," Adam said. "Gwildor, will you help us."

Gwildor looked nervously between the faces of his four companions. He swallowed hard and nodded.

"I will."

He picked up the Cosmic Key and pressed a few buttons. Musical electronic noises emanated from the device. Finally, he pressed the large red button. A thrumming, melodious, harmonic, sound filled the small cave. The crown of forked spikes on the Key expanded and began to spin slowly. A few feet in front of Gwildor, right about where the entrance to the cave was, a shimmering portal flickered into being.

"Quickly," Gwildor cried over the noise. "Go through now!"

Without another word, all five of them stepped through the doorway.

# Chapter 4

The portal slammed shut behind them, leaving Adam, Adora, Teela, Catra, and Gwildor in the darkened entry hall of Castle Grayskull. Besides the low hum of distant ancient machinery, the room was eerily silent.

"Ok, this is way too quiet," Catra muttered. "I expected to pop out in the middle of an army."

"Sorceress," Adam whispered. "Sorceress!"

There was no response, and the lights remained dim. Catra's eyes adjusted to the gloom the quickest, and she noticed something different from when Adora and Adam had brought her here before.

"Hey," Catra said, "wasn't there a wall over there before?"

After a few moments, when his eyes had adjusted, Adam saw what she was talking about. The far wall opposite the entrance to the castle had been adorned with a complex engraving depicting He-Man and the Sword of Power. Now that wall was absent, instead revealing a doorway and a flight of stairs leading up.

"A secret door?" Adora wondered aloud.

"I never even knew there *was* a door there," Adam replied.

"Let's go," Teela said. "Quietly."

Cautiously, the five of them made their way through the door and up the stairs. Adam and Adora had their swords at the ready. Teela had a hand up, ready to cast a spell at a moment's notice. Catra had her claws out and strained her ears into the dark for any sign of approaching danger.

Another massive door stood open at the top of the stairs leading into what had to be the largest chamber within the castle any of

them had ever seen. The room was hexagonal, easily three hundred feet across. The walls were lined with fifteen foot tall statues of robed figures, their faces obscured by hoods. Above the statues, the faintly glowing crystalline walls sloped inward. It was hard to judge the angle and therefore how high the ceiling ultimately was, but at the room's apex was some kind of large metallic iris, currently closed. A walkway stretching out before them led to a central platform about fifty feet wide, at the center of which was a large crystal throne.

The chamber resembled Horde Prime's throne room aboard his flagship enough that it made Adora shivver. She looked to Catra to make sure she was ok. Catra's hand was absently rubbing the nape of her neck, but she caught Adora's gaze and nodded.

"Mom? Dad!" Adam suddenly cried. Beside the throne on the central platform, he'd spotted two figures standing within a shimmering column of dim light.

The five of them raced across the walkway and to the prisoners.

"Adam," King Randor said. "Adora! What are you doing here?" He and Marleena pressed their hands against the inside of the energy field containing them.

"Rescuing you, of course," Adam replied. "Teela, can you bring this field down?"

Teela held out a hand toward the field and concentrated.

"It's not magic," she said. "Even if it was, I don't think I'd be able to dispel something Skeletor put up."

"So it's tech," Adora said. "Must be part of the castle's defenses."

"Sorceress!" Adam called again. Still, the hologram did not appear. "Why won't she answer?"

"Gwildor," Adora said. "Could that Key open a portal inside of this force field?"

“Of course,” Gwildor replied. “But it will take time to calculate the tones.”

“Then get started,” she said. “We’re going to get you out of here.”

“Adora, Adam,” Marleena said. “Listen to me. You can’t be here. If Skeletor captures you, too-”

“I’m not leaving without you,” Adam said.

Catra moved over near the throne, keeping watch on the entrance and listening for anyone approaching. She noticed a pedestal at the right hand of the throne. The slot and the shape of the top of the pedestal looked like a perfect fit… for Adam’s sword.

“I have a bad feeling about this,” Catra said. “Gwildor, how much longer?”

“I don’t know,” the locksmith said. “I’m working as fast as I can.”

Suddenly, the chamber filled with bright light. Everyone had to squint against the abrupt change. Catra could hear footsteps stomping rapidly up the stairs. Lots of them.

“We need to move,” she cried.

Within moments, scores of bots and armored soldiers swarmed into the chamber. They filed off in either direction, taking up position beside the statues while others made their way across to the front edge of the central platform. They were surrounded. The Key in Gwildor’s hands gave out a high-pitched ringing hum.

“Uh-oh…” he said.

“Is the door ready?” Adam said.

“No,” said Gwildor. “Another door is opening…”

As he spoke, a portal appeared at the entrance to the room. The purple robed figure of Skeletor stepped through, followed by his

chief lieutenant, Evil-lyn. The portal snapped shut behind them.

“Gwildor,” Catra said, “get down. Try to stay out of sight.”

Skeletor struck his staff imperiously on the crystalline floor.

“Everything comes to he who waits,” Skeletor rasped. “And I have waited a very, *very* long time for this moment.”

"Let them go," Adam demanded.

"I don't think so," Skeletor chuckled in response. “No, they will watch as I take all the power of Grayskull, as I become supreme ruler of this and every other world. And then they will be destroyed.”

Adam’s hand clenched on the hilt of his sword.

“Keep working Gwildor,” Teela whispered.

“Throw down your weapons,” Skeletor continued. “Pledge yourselves to me, or you will join them.”

“It’s not them you want, it’s me,” Adam said. “This has always been between us.”

“Silence!” Skeletor bellowed. “You *will* surrender to me, you will relinquish the Sword of Power, and you will bow before me.”

Evil-lyn thought she heard something as he spoke, a sound similar to that of her master’s Cosmic Key. She took a few steps to the side and spotted a tuft of orange hair sticking out from behind the legs of the prince and his friends. She saw…

“It’s the locksmith,” Evil-lyn said. “The little worm has another Key!”

“What?” Skeletor cried. He looked and saw him, the Thenorian crouched behind the others frantically pressing the buttons on a

second Cosmic Key. Fury welled up within him, and he roared, "Kill him!"

Bots and soldiers opened fire from all directions. Adam and Adora transformed in a flash. Teela ducked for cover behind the force field. She-Ra changed her sword into a shield and crouched in front of Catra and Gwildor to protect them. He-Man deflected incoming blaster fire with his sword, but it was clear they weren't aiming for him. Teela fired back with blasts of magic, but it was clear they were hopelessly outnumbered.

"Gwildor," Catra shouted. "That Key can get us out of here, right?"

"Of course," Gwildor replied.

"Then do it."

"Where?"

" *Anywhere!* "

Gwildor pressed a bunch of buttons on the Key at random and pressed the red button, and the musical hum sprang to life once more. A swirling, flashing portal opened in the air beside them.

The Key hanging from Skeletor's belt began to emit a resonant whine. He grasped the device, realizing now what it had meant when the Key had done the same twice before that day.

"Stop them!" he bellowed. "Bring me that Key!"

"Catra…" Adora began.

"Adora," Randor called from within the field. "Go. You'll find a way to stop Skeletor. I know it."

"We'll come back and save them, Adora," Catra said. "I promise."

Adora blinked away the tears welling in her eyes. "Teela," she called. "Through the portal, now!"

Teela nodded. She sprang out from cover and dove through the doorway. Catra went through next. Adora scooped Gwildor up in her free arm.

“Adam!” she cried. “Let’s go!”

“No!” he protested, still deflecting laser blasts with his sword. “I won’t leave them!”

“Adam,” Marleena pleaded. “You have to go. Eternia needs you. Eternia needs He-Man.”

“We’re so proud of you, son,” Randor added. “Escape now, and come back to stop Skeletor for good.”

Meanwhile, Evil-lyn had made her way around the edge of the room, looking for a clear angle to see Gwildor. She spotted the locksmith held in She-Ra’s arm, still clutching the active Key. She quickly cast a spell, conjuring a snaring tendril of dark magic, and launched it at the Key.

“We’ll be back, I promise,” Adora said to her parents. Then to Adam, “I’m sorry.”

Adora’s shield vanished, and she grabbed Adam around the waist, lifting him off his feet.

“No!” he cried. “Adora!”

Evil-lyn’s magical lash struch and wrapped around the Key just as She-Ra leaped for the portal. The sorceress pulled back to reel the tendril in. The portal thunderously slammed shut, and her spell was severed.

Skeletor screamed in fury. Bolts of green lightning arced out from him, leaving several bots in a smoking heap.

“The Keys are connected,” he barked. “They’ll have to use it again, and when they do, we’ll trace them. Hunt them down and bring them to me.”

“It looked as if he was punching the keys at random,” Evil-lyn replied as she returned to his side. “They could be anywhere in the universe.”

“I don’t want excuses,” Skeletor fumed, shoving the Key into her hands. “I want them found. He-Man lives and possesses that Key. I must possess all, or I possess nothing.

Find. Them.”

# Chapter 5

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

When the locksmith had completed the device, he had pleaded to be set free. Skeletor took a great deal of delight in refusing him. Instead, he would keep the Thenorian under lock and key in the event that the device - the Cosmic Key - required repairs or modification. Then, once all was in motion, and Gwildor's talents were no longer required, Skeletor would again take great delight, disposing of him personally.

While the Key was under development, Skeletor had set about drawing up his plan. The data he'd copied from the ancient vessel that had borne He-Man's new friends to Eternia was of tremendous help. Updated star charts, details on Horde Prime's resources and facilities, locations of other critical First Ones colonies, all were essential to Skeletor's ultimate design. This would be the last campaign, the final stroke in his long battle with He-Man. And Skeletor would relish in taking everything that the young prince held dear away from him before finally ending his life.

Once the Cosmic Key was complete, the first step was to take Tri-Klops and a force of soldiers to a Horde manufacturing planet. The clones living in the vicinity, having abandoned the factory after Prime's hive mind collapsed, were driven away easily enough. It was a similarly simple matter to get the plant up and running again as it was mostly automated. A few modifications to designs to fit Skeletor's tastes, and the facility was soon churning out battle-ready bots by the thousands.

Similar steps were taken at old Horde shipyards, producing enough starships to provide air and space superiority over Eternia, Etheria, and any other worlds that would require subjugation as the plan moved forward.

Lastly, Skeletor travelled alone to several worlds once controlled by his people. The Eye of the Galaxy had never been completed, but the First Ones had installed magic siphons on several worlds before Horde Prime had wiped them out. A number of them were still intact, collecting magic for the last thousand years. Skeletor made sure that those which were still functional could establish contact with Castle Grayskull.

The preparations were nearly complete. He sent spies to Etheria to locate the planet's political and population centers. He mapped out his plans of attack and had the locksmith program the coordinates. In time, everything was in order, everything was prepared.

It was time.

Taking a portal from Snake Mountain to his manufacturing world, Skeletor sent thousands of bots to attack the capitol city and castle on Eternia. He sent thousands more to Etheria to keep She-Ra and her people occupied. (It was during this phase that Skeletor's Key made a strange chirping sound, but it did not seem to affect its functionality, so he ignored it.)

With the attacks underway, he opened a portal into the first place he'd made Gwildor program the Key for: Castle Grayskull.

"Unauthorized presence detected," an artificial voice echoed through the darkened crystalline chamber. Red light began to emanate from the walls. "Security protocols now engaged."

"Administrative override," Skeletor said calmly. "Authorization: Keldor two-eight-six-two-seven."

A pause.

"Acknowledged," the voice replied. The holographic image of the Sorceress appeared. "Welcome councilman. How may I assist you?"

“First,” Skeletor began, “revoke all administrative privileges from all other users.”

“Confirmed.”

“Now, open the Eye control center.”

“Confirmed.”

With a grinding of stone that had sat unmoved in centuries, the far wall depicting a mural of He-Man began slowly sinking into the floor, revealing a set of ascending stairs. Another use of the Cosmic Key, and Evil-Lyn arrived, accompanied by a platoon of soldiers and bots. They stormed into the chamber above. Skeletor conferred with Evil-lyn on the progress of the battle and took a seat on the crystal throne.

“After all this time,” she’d said, “Grayskull is ours.”

“No!” Skeletor barked. “Mine.”

He regarded the pedestal beside the throne. The slot in the top sat ready to hold the final piece in Skeletor’s endgame: the Sword of Power. And steps were already underway to ensure that He-Man would bring it to him. The press of a few buttons and activation of his Cosmic Key, and, right on schedule, a squad of bots ushered King Randor and Queen Marleena into the Castle.

Skeletor engaged a force field to trap and hold them, and conjured his illusory visage in the sky  to inform the world, but especially He-Man, of the King and Queen’s capture.

He stationed his battalion outside the Castle to intercept and capture Prince Adam when he came to save his parents. What was unexpected, was the prince and his friends somehow entering the Castle without his detection, including his sister, She-Ra. (Again, his Key had made the strange chirping sound) No matter. They would be captured or killed, and ultimate power would be his.

Then came the revelation of Gwildor's escape and his second Key.

"I don't want excuses," he'd said. "I want them found. He-Man lives and possesses that Key. I must possess all, or I possess nothing. Find. Them."

They must be found. They must be brought back. Skeletor would not be denied. He would take He-Man's power. Then he would take his world. Then, he would take his life.

He was Skeletor, *and he would not be denied.*

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Adora fell into cold, muddy water. She'd dropped out her She-Ra form as she'd emerged from the portal. She stood, coughing and sputtering, and looked around for the others. They were in a grimy pond somewhere in a forest She spotted Teela leaning against a tree catching her breath and Catra angrily wringing dirty water out of her hair. She felt something bumping against her leg under the water's murky surface. She reached down into the water and felt a tiny hand. Adora hauled Gwildor up out of the water, gasping and spitting.

"Is everyone alright?" Adora asked and she sloshed through the hip-deep water to set Gwildor on the shore. Catra and Teela nodded.

"You left them," said Adam's voice from behind Adora.

"Adam…" Adora began, turning to face him.

"You *left them!* " Adam shouted, shoving her back a pace.

"Adam!" Teela scolded.

"Hey, back off," Catra warned, slipping back into the water to put a hand on Adora's shoulder. "There wasn't a way to win back there."

Adam huffed and turned away. “We could have tried,” he said.

“We were surrounded and outnumbered,” Adora said indignantly. “You think I *wanted* to leave them behind?”

“You’ve only even known them for like a year!” Adam shouted. “ *I* grew up with them.”

“Yeah,” Adora said cooly. “I know.”

“So *you* may be ok with leaving them behind for Skeletor to do who-knows-what to them,” he accused. “But I’m not.”

“I am *not* ok with it,” Adora replied, her voice rising now too. “There’s nothing I want more than to save them. I love them too, y’know!”

“ *Well obviously not as much as I do,* ” Adam roared.

The instant he said it, he wanted to take it back. The tears and look of hurt welling up in his sister’s eyes made his heart drop into his stomach.

Adora turned and splashed out of the muck and away into the trees.

“Adora, I…” Adam started.

“Don’t,” Catra said with a furious glare. She followed Adora into the woods.

Adam walked over to the muddy bank and sat down, his head in his hands.

Catra found Adora sitting on a fallen log with her face in her hands. She hadn't gone more than a few dozen paces from the pond. Catra sat down on the log next to her and put a hand on her knee. Without a word, Adora leaned against Catra, but still kept her face hidden, her shoulders shaking with sobs she tried to keep silent.

"Y'know, speaking as someone with *a lot* of experience lashing out when they're upset, he didn't mean any of that," Catra said. "Not that that excuses it," she added quickly. "He definitely crossed the line." She put an arm around Adora's shoulders.

"I can't believe he would really just throw that in my face," Adora said, putting her hands down in her lap. "As if I *decided* not to grow up with them…"

"So be mad," Catra replied. "As mad as you need for as long as you need. He was a jerk, and his being upset doesn't excuse that." She lifted Adora's chin to look at her. "But right now, we have a job to do. I promised you we'd save your parents, so that's what we're going to do. We go back to Etheria to get some backup, then it's back to Grayskull to rescue them and stop Skeletor."

Adora wrapped her arms around Catra in a tight hug.

"I love you," she said.

"I love you too," Catra replied. "And you better be grateful, because I am *soaked* and I hate it."

Adora laughed at that. Catra kissed her on the forehead.

A few minutes later, Catra and Adora had returned to the others beside the pond. Adam didn't look up.

"So what's the plan?" Teela said.

"We need to go back to Etheria and get reinforcements," Adora said. "We need to get mom and dad out of that force field, so we'll need Bow, Entrapta, or Hordak for the tech."

"With Skeletor *and* Evil-lyn there waiting for us, we'll need some more magical firepower, too," Teela said.

"So then we need Glimmer or Micah," Catra said. "Ideally, both. Then I say we bring along at least one other all around heavy

hitter. Maybe Frosta or Scorpia.”

“Then that’s the plan,” Adora said.

“Whatever you need,” Adam chimed in, still not looking his sister in the eye. “I’ve got your back.”

“Gwildor,” Adora said, “the Key can get us back to Etheria and then right back into that room we left in Grayskull, right?”

“Of course,” Gwildor replied. “The Key stores all its previous departure and arrival points in its memory. I just have to press the energize key…” he reached for the Key strapped to his back… then his eyes went wide. He slid the strap around his chest, revealing the clasps that once held the device to be broken. “Where *is* the Key...?”

"Oh you've *got* to be kidding," Catra snarled.

"Gwildor," Adora said, her voice cracking, "where's the Key!?"

"Don't panic, don't panic," Gwildor said. "Portals are set to close when the Key comes through. The portal we came through closed, so the Key is definitely on this planet. Probably not too far away."

"How far is 'not too far,' Gwildor?" Adam said.

"Well," he began sheepishly, "not too far in a planetary sense. So probably not more than somewhere within a hundred miles of here? ...probably…"

Catra's ear and Adora's eye twitched in frustration.

"There's nothing for it, then," Teela said. "We'll just have to fan out and look for it."

"We're on a completely alien planet," Catra said. "We have no idea what could be out there, so nobody goes anywhere alone."

"Right," Adora added. "Catra and I will search this way, you, Adam, and Gwildor search that way. Try to cover as much ground as you can. We'll meet back here in two hours."

Everyone nodded, and the groups split off to begin their search.

=======

About half an hour later, Adora and Catra came upon a strange sight at the top of a steep slope. There was some kind of metal fence or barricade stretching off in either direction just beyond the treeline. Beyond the barricade lay what was very clearly a road of some kind. It looked similar to some of the paving in the Fright Zone which had been done with a mixture of tar and fine gravel. This road was marked with faded paint lines - white on either side with a double band of yellow down the center. The road stretched off in either direction, disappearing around a bend among the trees.

“Well, at least we know the planet is inhabited,” Adora said.

“Something’s coming,” Catra said, her ears perking. “I hear some kind of engine. Approaching fast.”

They ducked down behind the metal barrier as a few moments later, a vehicle cruised by on the far side of the road. It rode on four wheels and didn’t appear to be armed or armored in any way. The blue paint was chipped and rusted in places, and the boxy cockpit near the front had large glass windows on all sides. Behind the cockpit was what appeared to be an open-topped cargo section of some kind? They didn’t get a very good look at the pilot, but with the glimpse they got, it did seem to look more or less like plenty of Etherians or Eternians. Within moments, the pilot and it vehicled had passed and disappeared beyond the curve in the road.

“Come on,” Catra said, hopping over the barrier and starting along the road after the vehicle.

“We’re following them?” Adora asked.

“Well, if there’s vehicles driving around maintained roads, there’s bound to be a town or village nearby,” Catra said.

“And if there’s people,” Adora realized, “then maybe someone’s already seen or found the Key!”

“Exactly. Let’s go.”

=======

Adam, Teela, and Gwildor had also found signs of civilization. They’d come across an area where the trees thinned out and the grass was cut short. There were several wooden tables and roofed pavilions scattered about, as well as a cluster of brightly colored metal and plastic tubes that somewhat resembled children’s playgrounds on Eternia.

It was under one of these wooden tables that Gwildor made an unsettling discovery, crying out in shock after pulling something out from under a table.

“What is it, Gwildor?” Adam said.

“Oh, it’s awful!” the locksmith said, shaking his head.

The object in question was some kind of bucket, but it was flimsy. It appeared to be made of wax-coated white paper, adorned with red stripes and some markings or glyphs. Adam looked inside and his eyes went wide. It was half full of bones. Tiny bones, stripped of any flesh.

“Oh, that’s super messed up,” Adam said, turning away in disgust.

“Let’s keep on guard and make sure we stay out of sight,” Teela said. “I’m not sure I want to meet the locals if they’re leaving buckets of bones laying around.”

=======

Kevin woke suddenly to a loud thud and what sounded like gravel spraying his bedroom window. He scrambled out of bed, his heart pounding. He glanced at his alarm clock. The red numbers gleamed in the dark - 3:19pm. Almost two hours early. Ugh. He pondered if it was even worth trying to go back to sleep before the gig tonight as he made his way to the window to look for the source of the sound that woke him up. Squinting into the afternoon sunlight over the small yard outside his apartment, he couldn’t help his eyes going wide in spite of the glare. There was now a crater some ten feet wide in the middle of the  yard.

He pulled on a shirt and stepped outside for a closer look. In the bottom of the crater sat a cylindrical object about eighteen inches long and six wide. It was mostly black and covered in brass buttons. The top tapered in and was crowned with weird little spiky silver forks. Lights on the thing were blinking and it emitted a soft hum. He looked up and around into the clear afternoon sky. No sign of a plane or helicopter or anything. Where in the world had this thing come from?

Chapter End Notes

Bonus points if you can call out what I'm basing this fic on. ;-)

# Chapter 6

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Kevin glanced again at the blue canvas backpack in the passenger seat beside him. He drummed on the steering wheel, eager to experiment further with the device.

When Kevin had stepped cautiously into the crater in the small yard outside his apartment, he gently patted the side of the blinking object with his fingertips, discovering to his surprise that it wasn't at all hot. He was then further surprised when, upon grasping the device to extract it from the crater, that it emitted strange, synth-like notes like some kind of instrument. He took it inside and experimented with the buttons, eventually figuring out their pattern and finding a scale. Then, with slight trepidation, he pressed the big red button near the bottom.

A deep, bassy harmony filled the room. Some kind of haunting, pre-programmed melody began to play along with that undertone as the array of silvery spiked forks expanded, and flickering colored light appeared above it.

Kevin quickly pressed the red button again, and the music and lights stopped, the forks retracting to their original positions. He'd never seen anything like this. Some kind of synthesizer without a traditional keyboard layout AND a built-in laser light show? And what in the world was some weird, advanced musical instrument doing in a crater in his backyard?

Kevin tried calling his friend Charlie on the phone. There was no answer at the music shop, but Kevin found him at home.

"Charlie, hey! Why aren't you at the shop yet?" Kevin asked.

"Huh?" Charlie replied. "Oh, I'm taking my mom to a doctor's appointment. About to leave now, actually. Why?"

“Well…” Kevin considered how much to even try to describe about the device or where he found it. “I found a weird instrument today, and I was wondering if you’d ever seen anything like it.”

“You ‘found’ an instrument?” Charlie said skeptically. “What do you mean, ‘found?’”

“It’ll be easier to explain in person,” Kevin said.

“I will be in to the shop later on,” Charlie said. “Do you have time to swing by before your gig tonight?”

“Not really,” Kevin sighed. “I’m on my own for setup and sound check this time. I’ve actually got to head over to the school here in a few minutes.”

“Ok, I’ll drop by and check it out before I head to the shop. Say, around six?”

“Perfect! Yeah, that works,” Kevin said. “See you then. Bye, Charlie.”

“Bye.”

So Kevin had carefully wrapped the instrument in a towel and placed it in an old backpack, finished packing up his car, and headed for the school.

=======

“The signal lasted only a moment,” Evil-lyn explained to her master.

“Were you able to lock on?” Skeletor asked, still seated on the crystalline throne within Grayskull.

“Unfortunately, no,” she admitted.

“Continue monitoring,” Skeletor said. “When they activate it again, open a door and take them before they pass through theirs.”

“Should I ready a full battalion?”

“No. We don't know what might be on whatever planet they're on. Prepare a small strike force."

"Yes, my lord."

=======

Catra and Adora stared at the massive structure. It was easily as big as the palace in Brightmoon, if not anywhere near as tall. It looked like several enormous interconnected blocky buildings, each made of concrete or stone. Symbols and markings adorned the sides of the complex near the roof, and at least two column-and-arch adorned entrances were visible, each made up of glass doors and windows. And surrounding the place was an expanse of pavement a hundred yards across dotted with lamp posts. Hundreds of the strange wheeled alien vehicles, in a surprising array of shapes and colors, were parked in neat rows.

“What do you think it is?” Adora wondered.

“I’m not sure,” Catra replied. “Some kind of market maybe? I can smell food and cooking oil from here. And look…”

She pointed out the local aliens coming and going through the big glass doors. Many of those leaving were carrying plastic and paper sacks in a variety of sizes and colors.

“Whatever it is,” Catra continued, “I’M going to stick out like a sore thumb.”

“What do you mean?”

“Just look! Everybody here looks exactly the same. Nobody with horns or hooves or wings or antlers or anything.” She gestured to herself. “Let alone anyone with big ears, fur, and a tail.”

Adora thought for a moment and had an idea. She took off her jacket and untucked her shirt.

“What are you doing?” Catra asked.

“Help me cut this,” Adora replied, stretching out the hem of the shirt.

Catra understood. A few minutes later, Adora was sporting a bare midriff, the missing fabric now fashioned into a bandana that hid Catra’s ears. With Adora’s jacket tied around her waist, Catra’s tail was also concealed.

“Perfect,” Adora said. “We are now ready to infiltrate the giant alien marketplace.”

“You’re such an idiot,” Catra sighed.

“Yeah,” Adora chuckled, “I know.”

A few minutes later, the pair had crossed the parking area and, hand in hand, walked through the large sliding glass doors and into the complex.

=======

“Yo, Kevin!” Charlie called out as he crossed the gymnasium floor.

Kevin looked up from the tangle of cables he was in the midst of sorting and connecting, and waved.

“So where’s this weird instrument you ‘found’ today?” Charlie asked.

“Just give me one minute,” Kevin replied, “to get these wires hooked up.”

“Sure thing,” Charlie said, hopping up to sit on the edge of the stage. After a moment, Charlie said, “So I saw Julian on tv today.”

Kevin tensed slightly at the mention of the name. He said nothing and kept working on the cables.

“He was down at one of those protests against that Defense of Marriage thing,” Charlie continued. “Saw him on the news…You heard from him lately?”

“Not since he moved,” Kevin replied flatly.

“He looked good,” Charlie trailed off awkwardly. “Hey, why did you two break up anyway, huh? You guys seemed really-”

“Can we not talk about it,” Kevin interrupted. “We…we just wanted different things. Can we drop it now?”

“Yeah, man,” Charlie said. “Sorry.”

“Alright,” Kevin said, plugging in the last of the cables. “Now let me show you what I found.”

Kevin retrieved the device from the backpack and carefully unwrapped it from the towel. Charlie gasped.

“Dude, far out!” he exclaimed. “What the heck is it?”

“It’s some kind of synthesizer,” Kevin explained. “Here, listen.” He played a quick melody on some of the buttons he’d experimented with before.

“That sounds so cool!” Charlie’s face was lit up like a kid on Christmas. “Can I try?”

“Be my guest.”

Charlie, who was not as musically proficient as Kevin, messed around with the instrument for a few minutes, not really playing anything discernable.

“Now hit the big red button,” Kevin said. “The one near the bottom.”

Charlie located the button and pressed it. The deep resonant harmony filled the room, the haunting pre-programmed melody echoing in the high open space of the gym. And again, the drifting flickering light emerged from the new spinning metal forks at the top of the device. After half a minute of Charlie gawking slack jawed at the spectacle, Kevin reached out and pressed the red button again. The light and sound once again faded.

“How much you want for it?” Charlie immediately asked.

“I’m not selling it,” Kevin chuckled. “I want to play it. I just thought maybe you had some idea what it actually was.”

“Yeah sorry my friend, but I’ve never seen anything like it,” Charlie said, still marvelling at the device. “You said you ‘found’ it. What *exactly* did you mean by that?”

“You’re gonna think I’m crazy…” Kevin said.

“Try me.”

Kevin sighed.

“I found it in a crater in my back yard this afternoon.”

“You’re joking.”

“Afraid not.”

“So this thing, what, fell out of an airplane or something? Or from space?”

“I have no idea.”

“You’re not worried it’s like, radioactive or something?”

“...Well not until *now!* ”

Charlie continued to turn the instrument over in his hands, studying it from every angle.

“Can I…take this with me tonight?” he said at last.

“I don’t know…” Kevin said.

“C’mon, man,” Charlie pleaded. “Maybe I can figure out what it is. I just got a new modem hooked up at the shop, maybe I can find something on the Internet about this thing.”

Kevin sighed.

“Look, it’s not like you can really use it in the show tonight, right?” Charlie continued. “You didn’t master playing the thing *that* quickly.”

“Alright, fine,” Kevin said finally. “But I’m coming to pick it up right after the show.

“Deal,” Charlie said. He carefully wrapped the device up in the towel and zipped it back into the backpack. “See you later then. The ‘open’ sign will be off by the time you get there, but I’ll leave the door open. Just come on in.”

“Alright,” Kevin replied. “See you then.”

Charlie left the school, and Kevin resumed working on his sound check.

=======

“We have a signal lock,” Evil-Lyn reported.

“Finally,” Skeletor barked. “The strike team is ready?”

“Yes, my lord,” Evil-Lym replied. She raised a hand and beckoned. Four figures crossed the walkway to the throne platform here within the Eye control chamber and stood at fearful attention before their master.

“I’ve selected these warriors to deal with all contingencies on this unknown world,” Evil-Lyn explained.

“Tri-Klops,” (the tech expert stepped forward, his cybernetic eyepiece array rotating around his head, the various lenses whirring and focusing) “to deal with any technological obstacles.”

“The Beastman,” (the red-orange furred creature stooped low to the floor in deference to Skeletor) “to control any hostile native fauna.”

“Spikor,” (the hulking figure over seven feet tall, his tough purple hide covered in sharp spikes, cracked his neck) “for ranged combat.”

“And Blade,” (this warrior wore a suit of polished light metallic armor and carried a multitude of weapons to his namesake) “for close quarters combat and to lead the expedition.”

“Very well,” Skeletor said. He stood and approached the team. “You will go through to this alien world. Find the Cosmic Key and return it to me. Do as you please with the others, but bring He-Man and his sword back alive.”

“I am eager to cross swords with He-Man again, Lord Skeletor,” Blade said. “I will best him this time and present his blade to you.”

“Sorceress,” Skeletor called. The hologram shimmered into being beside him. “The item we discussed. Produce one now.”

The Sorceress raised a hand, and a thin shard of purple crystal appeared in Skeletor’s outstretched and expectant hand.

“Again, I want He-Man alive,” he said, offering the crystal dagger to Blade, “but if She-Ra interferes, *this* should take care of things.”

“Thank you, master,” Blade bowed as he accepted the weapon and stowed it in place of one of his many knives.

“Bring me He-Man. Bring me the Key,” Skeletor said as he activated his Key, the portal yawning open before him. “Do. Not. Fail me.”

Chapter End Notes

> At long last we are back, baby! Thanks for being patient for the return of this story. I'm sure I don't need to tell anyone that it's been a hell of a year. But I'm back at it an excited to bring you the rest of the tale. Enjoy!

# Chapter 7

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“All this searching on foot is most inefficient,” Gwildor complained.

“Well we’re just going to have to deal with it, Gwildor,” Teela replied.

“Easy for you to say,” the locksmith retorted. “Your legs are as long as I am tall!”

“Well, it’s not like we even have another option, Gwildor,” Adam said. Another person was walking toward them on the concrete pathway beside the road they were walking down. “Excuse me,” Adam hailed them, “but have you seen a-”

The pedestrian looked up at them, eyes widening as they took in their appearance, then quickly looked away and quickened their pace past them.

“Ok thanks,” Adam said with a sigh. “No one here will so much as look at us, much less tell us if they’ve seen the Key.”

“Well we don’t exactly blend in,” Teela said. “Between my staff, the sword on your back, and the fact that Gwildor here is three cubic feet of orange hair, it’s a wonder no one’s attacked us or called the authorities.”

“At least we finally figured out where that bone-bucket came from,” Gwildor said. “Significantly less terrifying to know it was just food refuse.”

“It’s getting dark,” Adam said. “How much time before we’re supposed to meet up with Adora and Catra back in the woods?”

Teela checked her tracker pad.

“We’ll need to head back pretty soon, actually,” she said.

“Do you smell that?” Gwilder chimed in.

Adam and Teela sniffed the air.

“Is that smoke?” Adam wondered.

Just then, they heard shouting in the distance. It sounded like someone calling for help. Without waiting for a response from his companions, Adam raced off in the direction of the pleas.

=======

Blade, Spikor, Beastman, and Tri-Klops stepped through the portal into a dimly lit corridor. The floor was speckled white tile, the ceiling was a low grid of square and rectangular panels, and the walls were lined with hundreds of narrow metal doors with larger wood doors at irregular intervals. There was no sign of movement, but a low rhythmic sound could be heard from somewhere. The warriors followed the sound to a pair of wide metal doors.

Tri-Klops’ headpiece rotated, engaging a different optical input.

“I’m picking up one heat signature on the other side of the door,” he said in a low voice. “And a higher electrical field than anywhere else.”

Blade nodded and drew one of his swords. Spikor readied the spike launcher on his left arm. Beastman wiped drool from the corner of his mouth with the back of his hand and growled.

“Stay alert,” Blade said. “He-Man could be waiting in ambush for us. On three. One…two…”

“You guys aren’t with the band, are you?” a voice suddenly said.

The four Snake Mountain fighters whirled to see a middle-aged man standing at a nearby intersection of the corridors. As soon as the man saw them all more clearly, his eyes went wide, and his gray-bearded jaw dropped open.

Spikor raised his arm and fired a volley of spikes. The old man ducked and screamed, the spikes punching into the narrow metal doors lining the wall behind him.

“No you fool!” Blade cried. “Don’t kill him; he might know where the Key is!”

The rhythmic sounds from beyond the double doors suddenly stopped.

“Gus?” called a voice, muffled by the doors. “That you? You ok?”

“So much for surprise,” Blade grumbled. “Three.”

=======

Everything for the show was set up. Kevin was on the stage warming up and practicing on his keyboard when suddenly, he thought he heard a voice cry out and a metallic clang from the hallway outside the gym. He stopped playing. Was that someone talking out there?

“Gus?” Kevin called, hopping down from the stage and starting toward the double doors. Had the old janitor dropped something? Hurt himself? “That you? You ok?”

Suddenly, the doors burst open as a tall, bald man kicked it open. He was wearing black leather armor with metal plates and…was that a sword? Before Kevin had time to process that, his eyes moved to the other three figures now framed in the open doorway. One was hulking and hunched, knuckle-walking like some orange, nightmare gorilla. Another stood head-and-shoulders taller than the others, its leathery purple hide covered in spikes. It sneered with a mouth full of sharp teeth from a flat, slit-nosed face. The last looked more or less normal except for the green metal ring around his head that rotated between an array of sensors and lenses.

Kevin froze. He didn't know whether to scream or run or pinch himself awake.

"Seize him!" the armored man shouted, pointing his sword at Kevin.

In a flash, the orange gorilla-thing bounded into the gym. Kevin stumbled back and tripped, falling hard on his backside. The sudden spike of pain from his bruised tailbone assured him this was no dream. He scrambled away, staggering and stumbling to his feet and trying to run. Where he intended to run to, he had no idea. He reached the edge of the stage and stopped, confused. Panic. The large speaker to his right suddenly exploded with sparks and ear-splitting static. A twelve-inch long gray spike was lodged in the now smoking speaker.

Kevin turned and looked back. The tall purple one was striding across the floor, its left arm raised, its wrist like the barrel of some living gun. Kevin's vision became filled with orange, and he realized the gorilla-thing had caught up to him. Without thinking, he dropped to his hands and knees and crawled under the stage as fast as he could. The gorilla-thing slammed into the stage, snarling as it tangled itself in microphone wires.

Get away! Run! Kevin crawled toward the back of the stage. Maybe he could make it to the emergency exit. He heard heavy footsteps on the stage above him as well as the sound of

equipment being knocked over. Then, inches in front of his face, a silvery sword blade pierced through the surface above. He screamed and started to turn right when another blade lanced down in his path. He scrambled left instead, hearing yet another blade thrust through the stage above just behind him. He barely felt the tug as the blade pierced the fabric of his jeans and tore free.

Kevin crawled out from the edge of the stage and to his feet. There, not three feet away, was the rotating-robot-eyes man.

"Gotcha!" the man shouted.

Kevin grasped behind him for anything to defend himself with. He felt something and swung it as hard as he could. He felt a slight pang of guilt as Alicia's bass guitar stuck the figure in the side of the head and snapped off at the neck. The robot-eye left reeling from the blow, Kevin sprinted for the nearest door. He chanced a look back as he yanked the door shut behind him. The stage, the equipment on it, and the decorations were in flames.

The Beastman gave chase, ripping the door off its hinges in the process. He stalked into the space, sniffing for his quarry. He picked up the scent of dozens of people or creatures as well as strange chemical smells. Low wooden benches stood before more rows of the narrow metal doors. Turning a corner, the Beastman spotted him. They boy had his back turned, rummaging through a wheeled cart of some kind. Beastman growled, a deep rumble low in his throat. The boy spun around, a large white bottle in his hand, and splashed liquid into the Beastman's face. The liquid burned his eyes, nose, and throat. His acute sense of smell was overwhelmed by the acrid chemical stink.

Kevin bolted for the emergency exit, dropping the bleach bottle on the floor behind him. He ducked through the door out of the locker room and into the night, the monstrous gorilla-thing's pained howls echoing behind him.

=======

The interior of the enormous market had been breathtaking in its own right. Hundreds of people bustled about up and down the enormous main hallway. Glowing, buzzing, multicolored tube lights, so doubt forming words and sigils, adorned the doorways of brightly lit shops on either side. Additional carts and stalls formed a seemingly informal median down the wide corridor. And above, another floor of shops all connected by balcony walkways and a grand, arched glass ceiling above it all.

Once Catra and Adora had gotten over the initial spectacle, they set about trying to ask if anyone had seen the Key. The handful of people they'd actually managed to get to stop and talk to them didn't know anything and hadn't seen anything resembling the Key. Adora was focused on asking around, but Catra couldn't help being hyper-aware of how people around them were looking at them. Her ears and tail were hidden, and her short light brown fur could be mistaken for skin at a distance, but Catra still felt like she stood out terribly. Everyone around them looked the same; looked like Adora, Adam, Bow, or Glimmer in general appearance. But almost everyone had light skin like Adora. There were a few people with darker skin like Bow, but no one at all with orange skin like Glimmer and Entrapta or any other colors for that matter. The feeling of so many eyes watching her made her cling to Adora's arm for comfort. Eventually, they followed their noses to a part of the market with an array of food vendors and a multitude of people eating at small tables.

"You try sample?" a small woman said suddenly to them. She was standing in front of one of the food stalls with a tray, holding out an offering of cooked meat on tiny sticks. "Our bourbon chicken the bomb diggity."

Adora and Catra accepted the samples and tasted them as they continued walking.

“I don’t know what a bourbon chicken or a diggity is,” Adora said, “but this stuff is really good!”

Unfortunately, the plastic cards and green strips of cloth that the people on this planet apparently used as money were nothing like the handful of Etherian currency Adora and Catra were carrying, so there’d be no getting alien cuisine on this outing.

“Just as well,” Catra said, crossing her arms and hunching her shoulders. “Let’s just go and try looking somewhere else. I feel like everyone here is staring at me.”

Adora wrapped Catra in a hug and kissed her forehead.

“Ok,” she said. “We can go.”

“There they are,” another voice said. “Disgusting.”

Catra and Adora looked, and there was an older woman standing with a heavyset, mustachioed man in some kind of uniform.

“I’m going to have to ask you two to leave the mall,” the man said. “This is a public establishment, and we’ve gotten some complaints.”

“Complaints about what?” Catra asked. “We aren’t doing anything.”

“There are kids here,” the man said. “You just need to take all this,” he gestured at them vaguely, “someplace else.”

“No,” Adora said. “We aren’t doing anything wrong, we’re not hurting or bothering anybody. Just leave us alone.”

“Adora,” Catra said, “maybe we should just go. We were leaving anyway…”

“Are we going to have a problem here, miss?” the man said, hooking his thumbs condescendingly into his belt.

“I don’t know,” Adora replied. “Are you going to make a problem here?”

“Have it your way,” the man said, unhooking a pair of silver shackles from his belt. “I’m placing you under arrest for public indecency.” He grabbed Adora’s arm.

“Hey, don’t touch her!” Catra shouted, shoving the man away. As he stumbled back, he grabbed at her and pulled off the bandana, and Catra’s ears popped out.

There were gasps and murmurs from around them, as several people had turned their attention to the confrontation. Catra glanced around, seeing all eyes on them. She grabbed Adora’s hand.

“Let’s go,” she said, and the two of them took off running back toward the entrance.

=======

Kevin had no idea where he was running to, he just had to get away from those…things. He suddenly realized he was shouting, crying for help. He stopped, worried the monsters might hear him and follow. He spotted the hardware store up ahead. Maybe he could lose them in their supply lot? He reached the chain link fence and clambered up and over. He could hear footfalls and shouting back from the direction he’d come, so he ducked between pallets of bricks and tried to keep quiet.

Tri-Klops had his infrared sensor engaged, and the four warriors raced along following the fading heat of the boy’s footsteps on the pavement. Blade urged them all to go faster, while Beastman, half dragged along by Spikor, continued to snarl and snort, still trying to recover from the chemical the boy had attacked him with. The

tracks approached a barricade of interwoven metal wires and reappeared on the other side.

“He went in there,” Tri-Klops informed them.

Blade drew a sword and hacked a hole into the barrier for them to pass through.

From his hiding spot, Kevin saw the attackers filing through the hole in the fence. They started one way, so Kevin moved as quickly and quietly as he could in the other direction. He kept glancing over his shoulder; he could hear them moving around, shouting to each other, searching for him. He rounded a corner beside a large stack of plastic pipes and nearly ran headlong into a young blonde man in a pink vest.

“Are you alright?” the young man asked. “Was that you calling for help?”

“Quiet!” Kevin replied in a harsh whisper. “We’ve gotta get out of here. There’s these…monsters after me.”

“Monsters?”

“This hairy orange gorilla-thing and a guy with a sword,” Kevin realized he must sound crazy, raving about monsters at a complete stranger. “Look, we just have to get out of here, ok? Just keep quiet.”

“I found him! He’s here!” Kevin recognized the voice of the robot-eye guy.

“Get behind me,” the young man said, stepping between Kevin and the approaching attackers. Was that a sword on his back, too?

“No!” Kevin cried. “Just run!”

“You!” said the man with the swords as he stepped into view.

“Yeah,” said the stranger, as he drew the sword from his back and held it straight up into the air. "Me."

“By the Power of Grayskull!”

Chapter End Notes

This chapter involved the weirdest research I've ever had to do for a story. I had to make sure the slang phrase "bomb diggity" was a thing in 1996. XD

# Chapter 8

Despite the bruises and scrapes, Kevin suddenly wasn't sure he *wasn't* dreaming after all. The handsome young blonde man's sword erupted with crackling lightning and blinding light. When that light subsided, the stranger had changed in both appearance and attire. Now standing between Kevin and the monsters was an eight foot tall titan of a man, lean and muscular, with chin-length hair fluttering in a sourceless breeze.

"You sure you want to do this again, Blade?" the stranger said to the man with the swords.

"I'll best you this time, He-Man," the man called Blade sneered back. "And when I do, I'll proudly present your sword to Lord Skeletor myself!"

Blade rushed forward, and the stranger - He-Man, apparently - charged to meet him. Sparks flew as their swords clashed in a ferocious exchange. Kevin backed away from the fight, his head spinning in ever-deepening confusion. Suddenly, he heard a clinking of metal and looked up. The orange gorilla-thing had climbed up onto the stack of pipes and looked ready to pounce.

"Hey look out!" Kevin shouted to He-Man just as the monster leaped.

He-Man sent Blade stumbling backward with a swift heel-kick to the chest and whirled to face the leaping orange monster. He caught it by one outstretched clawed arm and hurled it over his shoulder and into the armored swordsman, the two falling into a tangled heap of limbs.

"I've got them," He-Man called. "You get out of here!"

Kevin nodded, his mind clearing slightly despite the stranger's distractingly bright smile. He turned to run and came face to face with the purple spike monster. The creature's thin lips curled into

a sinister grin as it leveled its spike launcher arm at Kevin. That grin vanished quickly though, as a ring of blue light suddenly appeared around its left shin, yanking backward and spilling the thing onto its ugly flat face.

Behind the now prone monster was a young woman with reddish-brown hair holding a staff in one hand and a matching blue glow around the other. She rushed past the purple thing to stand between it and Kevin. On the other side of the aisle, the swordsman and the gorilla-thing had gotten back to their feet.

"Fall back!" a voice shouted. It was the man with the robot-eye-ring. "Back to the portal, let's go!" He lobbed a metal ball at He-Man's feet which exploded in a burst of blinding light and deafening noise. When both had subsided, the monsters were nowhere to be seen.

"I'll follow them," the young woman said, breaking into a sprint. "They might have the other Key."

"Teela, wait!" He-Man called. "If they do, they're already gone. We need to regroup with Adora and Catra." He turned to Kevin, glowing again briefly and returning to his original form, and said, "Are you alright?"

"Uh…" Kevin stammered. He'd just been attacked by nonsense monsters out of nowhere, but his mind was a buzzing blank except for how pretty the stranger's eyes were. He blinked hard and shook his head, trying to clear it. "I think so. Um, thanks? He-Man?"

"It's just Adam," the stranger chuckled, returning the sword to the scabbard on his back.

"I'm Kevin," Kevin replied, trying to will the red out of his cheeks.

"Adam! Teela!" another voice suddenly shouted. Two more young women raced around the corner. One was tall and blonde with a sword in her hand (Seriously, what was with all these swords?),

the other was…were those cat ears? Kevin's head swam in confusion again.

"We saw the light from you transforming," the blonde one said. "What happened?"

"Had a run-in with some of Skeletor's lackeys," Adam said.

The blonde one relaxed her stance, and the sword in her hand flickered and disapeared.

"Speaking of," the one called Teela said, turning to Kevin. "Why were they after *you?* "

"I… I have no idea," Kevin said. "I don't even know what those things were. I was just setting up for my show, and they just burst in the room and started smashing everything and chasing me."

"What would Skeletor's goons want with some random kid?" the woman with the cat ears said.

"Can somebody please just tell me what in the world is going on?" Kevin blurted. "My stuff and my friends' stuff is all destroyed, freaky monsters tried to kill me, you're a cat person, and this guy turned into Conan the Chippendale, WHAT IS HAPPENING TO ME!?"

"Take a breath," Adam said, putting a hand on Kevin's shoulder. "It's alright, we're not going to let those guys hurt you. Once we find what we're looking for, we can make sure they won't threaten you or your planet again."

"My planet?" He felt dizzy.

"Let's all just slow down," the cat woman said. "Let's get some space, ok?"

The five of them made their way out of the stockyard, through the hole in the fence, and out onto the sidewalk. Kevin sat down on

the curb trying to regain his grip on reality.

“Alright then,” the cat person continued. “My name is Catra, and this is Adora. That’s her brother Adam and his best friend Teela. You said your name is Kevin, right?”

Kevin nodded, trying to slow his rapid shallow breathing.

“Ok, nice to meet you,” Catra said. “Now it’s too long a story to explain everything, but yes, we are from another planet. We’re trying to get home because Adam and Adora’s parents are in danger from the same guy who sent those goons that attacked you.”

Adora held onto Catra’s arm, looking very worried. Kevin’s head finally started to clear. As impossible as it all sounded, he knew he wasn’t dreaming. Somehow though, the most surreal thing was these two women being so openly affectionate toward each other. He stared in disbelief as Catra wrapped her arms around the distraught Adora, kissed her forehead, and whispered reasaurances to her.

“You guys are just totally out in the open with that, huh?” Kevin blurted.

“With what?” Catra asked.

“With being… y’know…” he replied sheepishly, “lesbians.”

“Well, Kevin,” Adora said, “to us, *you’re* the lesbian.”

“I- what!?” Kevin said. That little shock somehow started to clear the fog from his brain.

“Is that not…” Adora said, glancing around awkwardly. “I assumed that was your word for ‘aliens.’ Is that not it?”

This was real. These people, and the monsters who’d attacked him, were real live aliens. Ok.

“Never mind,” Kevin said, standing up and taking one last deep breath to calm himself. “So how did you all get here, and how do you get back?”

“We got here with a device called a Cosmic Key,” Adora said. “Gwildor here made… Wait, where’s Gwildor?”

The four aliens glanced all around.

“He was with us before we-” Teela began when a car came suddenly roaring and squealing around the corner, barely missing a lamp post and jumping the curb before screeching to a halt. Everyone had barely scrambled out of the way in time.

“What in the,” Teela shouted.

“Look everyone, native transport!” a delighted voice squeaked from inside the car. A small head with long pointed nose and ears poking out from a shock of wild orange hair popped up into view through the open window.

“Gwildor,” Adam said. “What did you do?”

“We’ll be able to search much faster and less conspicuously in this,” the tiny man, Gwildor apparently, said. “It’s a primitive combustion engine, but the locking mechanisms to enter and start it were easy enough to bypass.”

“Wait, you stole a car?” Kevin said, bewildered.

“Who’s your new friend?” Gwildor asked.

=======

Blade, Spikor, Beastman, and Tri-Klops walked quickly across the bridge to the platform that bore Skeletor’s crystal throne. Blade

seethed with frustration. The Beastman still coughed and snorted from the alien boy's chemical attack. Tri-Klops's eyepieces clicked and whirred nervously. Spikor was silent but tense. They reached the throne and each dropped to a knee.

"Well…" Skeletor rasped. "Where is He-Man? Where is my Key?"

"We…" Blade began clenching his fist. "We were unable to capture them."

"And yet you return," Skeletor replied, rising to his feet. "Were my instructions unclear?"

"We were ambushed by the Eternians," Tri-Klops interjected. Skeletor turned away from them, tightly gripping the haft of his ram-headed staff. "We thought it the best tactical option to retreat and regroup, to go after them with a larger force-"

Skeletor whirled back toward them, raising his staff in their direction. There was a bright flash of sickly green light, and there was suddenly a pile of ash where Spikor had been kneeling.

"I have suffered your incompetence for the last time!" Skeletor roared. "Failure after failure, years of uselessness! Now I stand at the cusp of total victory, our forces holding every advantage, He-Man separated from all his pathetic friends and allies, AND STILL YOU FAIL!"

The eyes of the head of his staff glowed again with that sickening green light.

"Give me one more chance, my Lord," Blade said. "I will not fail you again."

Skeletor growled.

"On the cusp of total victory," Evil-Lyn suddenly interrupted, crossing the bridge and standing at Skeletor's side, "perhaps it is unwise to destroy our own forces."

“Save your pity for yourself,” Skeletor barked, grabbing Evil-Lyn by the arm and shoving her into the midst of the cowering warriors. “Go, and return with He-Man, the sword, and the Key, or do not return at all.”

“I was not suggesting I go,” Evil-Lyn protested.

“Then you should not have spoken. Go. Take whatever forces you wish. Find He-Man and the Key. Contact me when you have them, and I shall come myself.”

“Yes, my Lord,” Evil-Lyn said, her jaw tightening.

“If you fail me,” Skeletor threatened, “I promise you, it will be for the last time.”

=======

Kevin had taken the wheel of the stolen car as none of his new alien friends had any idea how to operate one or what any of the traffic lights or signs meant. He navigated the familiar route toward Charlie’s music shop at the mall. The fact that he’d fallen into helping these strangers find their missing portal machine still felt surreal despite his acceptance that it really wasn’t a dream.

“It’s about this long,” Adam had described, holding his hands about eighteen inches apart, “tapered on one end with little silver forks and lots of brass buttons.”

“Wait, I have seen that!” Kevin had exclaimed. “I found it in a crater in my back yard this afternoon. It plays music and lights up when you push the big red button?”

“That’s it!” Gwildor had squealed.

“Where’s the Key now?” Catra had asked.

“My friend Charlie took it to his shop,” Kevin had explained. “He was going to try looking up what it might be online.”

“Then your friend is in terrible danger,” Teela had said. “If Skeletor knows it’s here, he might be able to track it to your friend's shop.”

“Can you take us there?” Adora had said.

So now Kevin drove, careful not to go too fast lest they attract the attention of a cop while driving a stolen car, toward the mall.

“So what does that word mean, anyway?” Catra asked from the back seat.

“What word?” Kevin replied.

“What you called me and Adora. Lez-beans?”

“Lesbian. It means, well, it means a woman who loves other women.”

“What a weird thing to have a specific word for,” Adora said.

“Well, at least here on this planet, most people don’t take too kindly to people like that,” Kevin said flatly.

“That must be what that soldier’s problem with us was,” Catra said.

“Soldier?”

“Some jerk in a uniform hassled us at that big market. Something about us being ‘indecent’ or something.”

“So nobody has a problem with that where you’re from?”

“It doesn’t even make sense to me why anyone anywhere would have a problem with it.” Catra leaned back in the seat and put her arm around Adora. “What business is to anybody who someone else is in love with?”

“Sounds like a nice place,” Kevin said with a sad little smile.

“Thank you, by the way,” Adam said from the seat beside Kevin. He put a hand on Kevin’s shoulder again. “Once we get the Key and get home, Skeletor’s forces won’t have any reason to come back here again.”

Kevin hoped it was too dark for any of them to see his cheeks flush. Adam was VERY handsome. And from a planet where apparently nobody cared if you were gay…

“It’s no problem, really,” he said. “I’ll just be glad when this is over. I don’t know HOW I’m going to replace all that destroyed gear though…”

“We have some friends  back home who are serious tech wizards,” Teela said. “Once we stop Skeletor, maybe we can visit again and one of them can fix your gear or build replacements.”

“That’d be great,” Kevin laughed. “Although the rest of my band would never believe it. ‘Sorry I smashed your bass fighting evil aliens, Alicia, but here’s a new one made by nice aliens.’ Should go over great.”

The mall proper was closed by the time they pulled into the vast parking lot. Catra groaned about how there were just here, that the Key had been RIGHT THERE, and they’d missed it. They parked close to the exterior entrance to Charlie’s shop. The sign in the window said “closed,” but the door opened easily when Kevin pulled. As soon as the door opened, they could all hear the familiar drone and distinct notes of the activated Key.

“Oh no,” Kevin gasped.

They all rushed inside to see a young man, Charlie, sitting on the store counter holding the active Key, grinning at the dancing lights emanating from the device.

“Hey Kevin,” Charlie said, his smile wide. “I didn’t expect you for a while yet. Something happen with the show? Who’re your new

friends there? Does she have cat ears?”

“Charlie!” Kevin cried. “Shut it off before they-”

But Kevin was cut off as the door and windows behind them suddenly exploded. A brilliant flash of purple light giving way to red smoke as they were showered with shattered glass and chunks of metal and concrete.

“Oh my god!” Charlie screamed. “Kevin, what it the world is going on!?”

“Get down! Take cover!” Adora shouted. Her sword reappeared in her hand. Adam drew his as well.

“Move in!” a woman’s cold voice called from beyond the smoke and dust.

“Evil-Lyn,” Teela said through gritted teeth.

“Destroy them all, and bring me that Key!”

# Chapter 9

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Laser fire blazed into the store, blasting apart guitars, keyboards, speakers, and all manner of equipment. Sparks, flames, and black smoke mingled with the residual crackling purple energy and red smoke. Adora had turned her sword into a shield and crouched behind it, laser blasts sparking and deflecting off its glowing surface. Everyone else was crowded on the floor behind her, doing their best to stay in cover.

“Kevin, what is going on!?” Charlie shouted over the roaring din.

“We can’t stay here,” Adora said, sweat already beginning to stand out on her brow. “They’re going to start coming in here after us, and we can’t stop that if we’re pinned down!”

“Hold on,” Teela said, standing up and raising her staff. She traced sigils in the air and chanted incantations, finally conjuring a magical barrier bisecting the store. The noise died down as laser blasts continued to collide with it, making a dull, hollow sound on impact.

“That won’t hold for long,” she said. “We need a plan.”

“Gwildor, the Key,” Adam said. “Can you get us out of here?”

Kevin snatched the Key out of Charlie’s trembling hands and handed it to Gwildor. Gwilder looked it over and huffed.

“The coordinates are all scrambled,” he said. “Someone’s been fiddling with it at random.”

“Yeah, sorry about that,” Kevin said. “To be fair, I thought it was just a musical instrument.”

“Can you fix it?” Teela asked.

“I can,” Gwildor replied. “But it’ll take me a few minutes to reset it and reprogram the coordinates.”

“Alright,” Catra said. “Charlie, Kevin, is there anywhere in this building that’d be good to hide?”

“Uh, security office?” Charlie offered.

“You know where it is?”

Charlie nodded.

“Ok, then here’s the plan,” Catra said. “Kevin, take Charlie and Gwildor to that office. Stay out of sight, and fix that Key. The rest of us get ready for them to come in. We keep them focused on fighting us so they don’t find Gwildor and the Key.”

Everyone nodded. They all rushed out of the music shop and out into the mall proper.

“Where do you want me to send us?” Gwildor asked as he scurried across the floor on his tiny legs.

“Brightmoon,” Catra said. “Original plan hasn’t changed. We get reinforcements, then back to Eternia to stop Skeletor.”

Kevin, Charlie, and Gwildor rounded a corner out of sight. Adora, Catra, Adam, and Teela all took up positions in the mall’s main thoroughfare outside the burning music shop. Inside, they could see Teela’s magic barrier cracking and beginning to flicker.

“Everybody ready?” Adora said.

Everyone nodded.

“Let’s do it,” Adam said. He raised his sword. “By the Power of-”

Glass crashed. Several figures suddenly dropped from above them, having smashed through the skylights. Everyone shielded

their eyes as shattered glass rained down upon them. At the same moment, the barrier in the store failed, and shiny black-carapaced bots started streaming through.

“By the Power of Grayskull!” Adam cried.

“For the Honor of Grayskull!” Adora followed suit.

As soon as the light of Adora’s transformation faded, she found herself face to face and crossing swords with Blade.

“You’re not the one I want,” he growled.

“Sad day for you,” Adora replied.

Adam squared off with a hulking blue-skinned man with a robotic claw-arm and a spiked metal lower jaw. The claw lunged forward, grasping for Adam’s sword, but he managed to pull away.

“If you want my sword, Trapjaw,” Adam said. “You just had to ask.”

Beastman growled as he stalked toward Teela.

“Hey fuzzball!” Catra shouted. Beastman turned to face her. Catra flexed her hands and extended her claws. “Let’s go.”

Teela turned her attention to the bots streaming through the music shop. She took a firm grip on her staff and charged a spell in her free hand.

=======

“Lucky for you, I’m a worlds-renowned locksmith,” Gwildor said as the security office door clicked open. He, Charlie, and Kevin filed in, Kevin closing and re-locking the door behind them. Gwildor hopped up onto the cluttered desk and began working on the Cosmic Key. Charlie still looked shaken and out of it.

“Charlie,” Kevin said. “You alright? You still with me?”

“My store…” Charlie stammered. “They blew up my store.”

“Yeah, sorry about that,” Kevin said. “But once these guys get their Key thing fixed, they’ll be able to go home, and the bad guys should leave too. Everything’s going to be alright.”

“Everything’s going to be… are you serious?” Charlie cried. “There’s no way my insurance is going to cover ‘random alien attack.’” He plopped down on a chair and put his head in his hands.

Kevin turned his attention to the bank of tv screens on one wall. He tried the series of buttons under the monitors until the camera feed switched to a grainy, black-and-white view of the main mall corridor. It looked like Adam, Adora, and Catra were engaged in battle with Skeletor’s soldiers. Teela appeared to be focusing on the horde of shiny black robots that were still coming in through the destroyed music shop.

“Hurry, Gwildor,” Kevin said. “How long can they hold all that off?”

“With He-Man and She-Ra,” Gwildor chuckled, “they’re the ones who should be worried!”

=======

“There’s no sign of the Thenorian or the Key, mistress,” Tri-Klops’ voice said through Evil-Lyn’s communicator.

“They can’t have gone far,” Evil-Lyn replied. “Keep scanning. I’ll summon Lord Skeletor when you find them.”

=======

Catra leaped aside as the Beastman threw a heavy punch with one massive fist. She ducked and weaved around him, darting in to swipe at his flanks with her claws. Beastman howled and roared from the wounds, throwing more heavy blows that the lithe Catra avoided easily.

“Missed again,” she laughed through a confident grin. “How do you hit anybody when you’re this slow?”

Beastman grabbed a heavy concrete planter and hurled it at her, leaves and mulch spilling across the floor. Catra dropped into a low roll forward to dodge under it, but that brought her into Beastman’s reach. Back on her feet at the end of the roll, Beastman caught her in the stomach with a backhanded blow that sent her skidding across the floor. She looked up to see him lifting another planter over his head to hurl at her. She sprang up and scrambled up one of the many columns, just avoiding the planter as it smashed into the spot she’d just been. Catra vaulted over the railing onto the upper floor, ducking out of sight as the Beastman hurled an entire cosmetics shop kiosk at her.

Teela, in cover behind another of the columns, tried her best to stem the flow of bots into the mall. She blasted them apart and set magical snares to trap them, but there were so many that a few kept getting through. Fortunately, not more than He-Man or She-Ra could handle alongside the other fights they were occupied with.

“Hey Adam,” Teela called. “How about that Kevin guy?”

“What about him?” Adam said, blocking a heavy blow from Trapjaw’s claw.

“You saw the way he was looking at you, right? Heads up!”

A bot slipped through her barrage, but Adam easily cleaved it in two without missing a beat in his fight.

“Is this really the best time to get into that?” Adam said.

“I’m just saying,” Teela teased. “How long have you been single now?”

Adam grabbed Trapjaw’s arm and threw him through the windows of another shop.

“Ok fine,” Adam said, exasperated. “He’s cute, alright? Happy?”

Trapjaw re-emerged from the store window and charged; Adam brandished his sword and charged to meet him.

Adora traded blow after blow with Blade, their swords ringing through the vast open interior space. Blade kept trying to dodge past her, eager to go after Adam, but Adora blocked his efforts.

“Get out of my way!” Blade roared.

“But I’m not done playing with you yet,” Adora smirked.

With a heavy blow, Adora knocked the sword out of Blade’s hands, but he simply drew two more from his back and continued the fight. Strike, feint, parry, riposte, block, slash, thrust. A frenzy of sword strikes flashed between them. Adora chanced a look to see how Catra was faring.

Up above, Catra sprinted, dodged, and rolled. Beastman had climbed up as well and was chasing after her, grabbing and throwing anything that wasn’t bolted down at her. She sprang off a wall to avoid one projectile, sprinting on all fours for the railing. Perching on it for a split-second, she leaped for the opposite balcony, clearing the twenty foot gap and rolling smoothly into a crouch. Across the way, Beastman roared and made the same leap, but far less gracefully, tumbling and crashing hard through the windows of another store.

Just as the Beastman climbed back out, covered in scratches and shattered glass, Catra rushed him, went into a slide between his legs, spun to kick first the back of one knee, then the small of his back. He went sprawling onto his face, and she leaped onto his back, raking her claws into his shoulders over and over. When he at last got his arms under him and started pushing back up to his feet, Catra vaulted off over his shoulders to run and gain some distance again. To her surprise and alarm, one massive hand lashed out and grabbed hold of her tail. Catra hissed as Beastman swung her by her tail and hurled her into one of the columns hard

enough to smash through it. She landed hard on the floor below in a shower of shattered concrete. Beastman roared and leaped down after her, fists clasped together for a hammer blow.

=======

Tri-Klops crept through the mall, avoiding the chaos of the pitched battle. He cycled through his various enhanced vision modes, looking for signs of the locksmith and his Key. He spotted residual heat from several pairs of feet, one of which was considerably smaller than the others. He grinned and followed the trail until it led to a steel door. It was painted to match the walls, unobtrusive except for a single word written in blocky black letters. Another cycle through the spectrum confirmed that beyond the door were three people, one half the size of the other two. "I found them," he whispered into his communicator. "I'll have the Key in mere moments."

Tri-Klops' grin widened as he selected two devices from his pack. One was a gadget he almost never had cause to use.

=======

Skeletor sat impatiently on the crystal throne in the Eye control chamber. Then a smoky apparition of Evil-Lyn materialized before him.

"Tri-Klops has located the Key and will take possession of it soon," she reported. "My forces are keeping-"

"And He-Man?" Skeletor interrupted.

"...He has not been captured yet," Evil-Lyn said. "He and the others are currently occupied in battle with my forces."

"Very well," Skeletor said, rising from the throne. "Prepare for my arrival."

=======

Inside the security room, Kevin watched the screens anxiously. He winced as he saw Catra get thrown through a cement support column from the upper floor to the lower. Gwildor still sat on the desk, punching away at the buttons on the Key and muttering to himself. Charlie sat silently in a chair by the door.

"Guys, open up," a voice said from outside the room. It was muffled, but it clearly sounded like Adam. "It's all over. They ran away. Come on out."

"Oh thank god," Charlie sighed, reaching for the door latch.

"Wait," Kevin said. He could still see Adam on a screen, fighting as He-Man. "Charlie don't, that's not-"

Too late. No sooner than Charlie had started to turn the doorknob, it flew open. There stood the man with the green robot eye ring around his head. With a manic smile on his face, he lowered the speaker-like device in one hand, kicked Charlie in the chest, knocking him onto the floor, and raised some kind of bulky gun at Gwildor.

"Gwildor, look out!" Kevin cried.

The end of the gun snapped open into a three-pronged claw, launched into the room and latched onto the Key, then a cable yanked the Key from Gwildor's hands and to the robot-eye man.

"Lord Skeletor thanks you," the man sneered before running off.

"No!" Kevin shouted and ran after him.

=======

The music shop was properly ablaze now. Thick smoke poured out into the main corridor. The harsh bell of alarms echoed through the space. Catra had managed to roll aside at the last moment, the Beastman's fists cracking the tiled floor where her head had been a second earlier. But he'd landed practically on top of her. He grabbed hold of one arm to prevent her scrambling away. She

slashed at his torso frantically with the claws of both feet and her free hand while he tried to get a grip on another limb.

"Catra!" Adora cried. She suddenly reached over Blade's shoulder, grabbed the straps of his armor, and threw him effortlessly across the corridor. She sprinted toward Catra, lowering one shoulder to ram into Beastman's side and sending him tumbling across the floor too.

"Thanks, princess," Catra said. She got to her feet, rubbing her arm where Beastman had gripped it. Suddenly, she spotted Blade, back on his feet, winding an arm back, a dagger blade between his fingers. Catra's eyes went wide, and she grabbed Adora, spinning them both to one side just as Blade's arm whipped forward.

Too slow! Catra felt a sharp pain in her hip as the dagger struck. Adora cried out, put a powerful arm around Catra's waist, turned to put herself between her and Blade, and unleashed a magical blast that hurled Blade crashing into a sunglasses kiosk.

"Catra, are you alright?" Adora asked as she put her down.

"It's not bad," Catra said, yanking the thin crystal knife out. "It just stuck in the muscle. I'll just be sore for a while, nothing serious."

"Adam!" Kevin's voice called out. Everyone turned to see him, his arm outstretched, pointing upward. "He found us! He took the Key!"

Adam followed where Kevin was pointing. There, sprinting along the upper balcony, was Tri-Klops, the Cosmic Key tucked under one arm. Adam started to crouch, ready to leap to the upper floor to stop him, but the momentary distraction allowed Trapjaw to seize him with his robotic claw. Trapjaw lifted He-Man off the ground, then slammed him back down headfirst.

"I've got him," Teela called, casting a snaring spell. But she was interrupted by Beastman hurling multiple destroyed bots at her,

forcing her to take cover.

Tri-Klops used a grapple-gun to ascend toward the shattered skylights. Adora rushed over to Adam, cleaved through Trapjaw's metal arm, and punched him in the chest hard enough to send him flying into Beastman.

"To the roof, now!" Adora cried as Adam pulled his head and shoulders out of the floor.

"Catra, come here," Teela called, conjuring a translucent magical platform an inch off the floor. Cata rushed over and stepped onto the platform. With Catra hanging onto her arm, Teela struck her staff on the platform, and it began to rise upward, carrying them both toward the skylight.

Seeing Blade, Trapjaw, and Beastman beginning to recover, He-Man and She-Ra met each other's eyes, nodded, and both leaped straight up and out.

=======

Lights flashed and sirens blared as the police cruisers and fire trucks converged on the shopping mall. Detective Lubic slurped another mouthful of bitter black coffee from a paper cup. What a crazy night. First the fire at the high school, now another at the mall with reports of shots fired as well. As he rounded the corner into the mall parking lot, he could see the smoke rising from the roof.

He sat the coffee on the dashboard and reached for his radio receiver to report in. But then he saw something that made him slam on his brakes, spilling coffee everywhere. Lubic threw the car into park and nearly fell out the door as he opened it. He stared up in disbelief. It was like someone had punched a hole in the sky. A huge ring of swirling purple light, thirty feet in the air and easily as wide across. Then, as if things weren't already crazy enough, something emerged from the sky-hole. What looked like some

kind of long, flat, levitating boat slid into view through the rift like some kind of magic trick.

“Mary, mother of God…” Lubic muttered.

=======

Adam and Adora landed on the roof, Teela and Catra seconds behind them. Tri-Klops was at the edge of the roof. He looked back at them nervously as they spread out, making sure he had no path to escape.

“Nowhere left to run, Tri-Klops,” Catra said. “Hand over the Key.”

There was a flash of purple and a roar of wind. Just beyond the roof’s edge, a massive portal yawned open, and a massive battle skiff drifted through, all sharp black angles and red-glowing canons. The rear of the skiff was shaped like a giant ram’s skull, and the deck was packed with even more bots. In the center of the ram’s head sat Skeletor on a gleaming black throne.

Teela acted fast. She cast a lasso of magical energy and snared the Key in Tri-Klops’ hands. She yanked it free, and it went sailing into the air.

“I’ve got it!” Adam cried, leaping up and catching the Key.

With a roar, the Beastman leaped up through the skylight. He rushed at He-Man, swiping at him with his claws and grasping for the Key. Adam backed away, dodging the strikes, trying to keep the Key out of reach.

“Adora!” he called, throwing the Key high over Beastman’s head.

Adora leaped and caught it, landing as the skiff reached the edge of the roof. The bots rushed onto the roof, spreading out on both sides, trying to surround them. Beastman snarled and broke away from Adam, heading now toward She-Ra. A swift leg-sweep from Catra spilled him onto his face.

“Get back inside,” Catra said. “Get the Key to Gwildor. We’ll catch up.”

Adora nodded and started toward the skylight, when a shimmering green barrier suddenly appeared over it.

“Leaving so soon,” taunted Evil-Lyn. She hovered in the air beside the battle skiff, drifting down onto the roof. With a shriek, she blasted She-Ra off her feet with a barrage of dark magic. The Key dropped, tones chirping as it hit the roof.

Tri-Klops rushed over and snatched up the Key. Adam caught up to him and punched him hard in the gut, the Key flying away. Catra caught it, but Beastman grabbed the back of her neck, lifted her off the ground, and yanked the Key from her grip. Teela blasted Beastman with magic, and he dropped both Catra and the Key. Catra grabbed the Key again and ran toward Adora. Evil-Lyn fired another barrage of dark magic, but Adora turned her sword into a shield and stepped between them to block it.

“What do we do?” Adora said. “The bots have us surrounded, and Evil-Lyn is blocking the skylight!”

“The floor!” Catra shouted. “Adam, smash through the floor!”

“Right!” Adam replied. He dropped to one knee and started punching and slashing a hole into the roof of the mall. Teela moved to his side and cast a shielding spell to cover him. In a few seconds, he’d made an opening big enough.

Catra threw the Key toward He-Man. He reached out for it as it arced through the night air.

“Enough!” Skeletor roared, unleashing a torrent of green lightning.

Adam, Teela, Adora, and Catra were all thrown off their feet, and the Key clattered to the ground, sparking and smoking. Adam was back on his feet in a flash, sword in hand, ready to charge at Skeletor’s battle skiff.

“One more move, He-Man,” Skeletor called, “and your friends die.”

Adam gritted his teeth, his hands tightening on the sword’s grip.

“Best listen to him, He-Man,” another voice called from behind him.

Adam turned to see Blade emerging through a metal door onto the roof. Kevin was in front of him, one arm twisted behind his back and a dagger held in front of his throat.

“Adam, I’m sorry,” Kevin said.

Adam’s eyes went wide. He quickly surveyed the roof. Bots all around them. The battle skiff’s cannons trained on them. Evil-Lyn, Beastman, Tri-Klops, and now Blade, all ready to fight still. He desperately tried to think of a way, any way, to get out of this…

“I offer you one chance, He-Man.” Skeletor said. “Return with me to Eternia as my prisoner, surrender your sword, and I shall spare their worthless lives.”

Adam looked to each of his friends in turn. Adora, Teela, and Catra all shared his determination to finish the fight; he could see it in their eyes. But Kevin… Kevin was terrified. This wasn’t his fight. And even with all the strength and speed of He-Man, there was no way Adam could possibly close the distance in time to stop Blade from using that dagger. Adam sighed.

There was no choice.

Adam transformed back to himself…and dropped the Sword of Power to the ground.

“Adam, no!” Adora cried.

Blade shoved Kevin aside and rushed toward Adam, snatching the sword off the ground and pointing it at him. Blade cocked his head toward the battle skiff, and Adam started walking.

“Adam, you can’t!” Teele said.

“I have no choice,” Adam said. “There’s no other way.”

Adam stepped onto the skiff where Tri-Klops shackled his hands behind his back.

“I believe in you guys,” Adam called. “All of you. I know you’ll find a way to stop him.”

“A touching sentiment, He-Man,” Skeletor chuckled.

“And the others?” Evil-Lyn asked. “Shall I destroy them?”

“Leave them alone,” Skeletor replied. “As long as I let them live, He-Man is bound by his word. Heroes are so very predictable.”

“But if they follow us-”

“It makes no difference now,” Skeletor interrupted. “They cannot stop me. No one can.”

Adora transformed back as the battle skiff floated away from the roof, fists clenched and tears in her eyes. Adam locked eyes with her as the skiff moved slowly back toward the portal back to Eternia.

“I believe in you,” Adam whispered. Though Adora couldn’t hear him, she knew what he’d said.

In moments, the skiff was gone.

“Get Gwildor,” Adora said, scooping up the still smoking Key. “We need to get to Eternia now!”

“I’ll go find him,” Teela said, rushing off through the door Blade had taken to the roof.

“Adora,” Kevin stammered, “I’m sorry. He just grabbed me and I… I didn’t know what to do.”

“It’s alright,” Adora said. “We’re going to save him. But we don’t have time to get backup. Catra, we need a plan to-” she stopped short.

Something was wrong. As the adrenaline of battle started to fade, Catra suddenly noticed she felt short of breath. He head was spinning, her vision tunnelling. She felt Adora catch her as her knees gave out.

“Catra!?” Adora cried. “What happened? What’s wrong?”

“I… I don’t know,” Catra said through shallow breaths.

Adora looked her over. She didn’t see any signs of injury. No wounds except… Adora quickly pulled up the side of Catra’s top…

and saw a web of dark purple veins slowly spreading from where the crystal dagger had struck her.

Chapter End Notes

We're in the endgame now, folks. Stay tuned for one more. Hope you enjoy.

# Chapter 10

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Skeletor strode triumphantly down the walkway to the central platform in the Eye control chamber. There waited the crystal throne, the dock for the sword, the hologram that was the Sorceress, and the king and queen, still captive in their force field. He looked up at the still-closed iris high above.

"The time has nearly come," he said. "Soon, everything will be in place, and I shall at last recieve my long-denied destiny."

"Men who crave power," Queen Marlena said, "look back over the mistakes and misdeeds of their lives, pile them all together, and call it 'destiny.'"

"An amusing bit of philosophy, your highness," Skeletor chuckled. "Here is my response."

He gestured, and Marlena and Randor looked to see Adam, his hands shackled, led across the platform.

"Adam!" Randor cried. "No!"

"I'm all right," Adam replied as Tri-Klops bolted the chain of his shackles to the floor. "Adora and the others are alive. They're coming."

"Will they now?" Skeletor laughed. "Even if they could, they will be far too late."

=======

"Adora, what happened?" Teela cried as she returned to the roof. Gwildor and Charlie trailed behind her.

“I’m not sure,” Adora said. “She’s been poisoned or something. Everything’s going to be alright, Catra. I’ll heal you.”

“Gwildor, the Key,” Teela said, passing the device to him. “Get us out of here, quick.”

“You’ve got this, Adora,” Catra said, mustering a weak smile.

Adora began to glow, holding Catra close in her lap. The glow spread to Catra, who hissed in pain as the veins of poison started glowing too.

“Stop!” Catra cried.

“Why?” Adora said, letting the magic fade. “What’s wrong?”

“Made it worse.”

Adora and Teela looked at the purple veins of poison. They were fading back to the dark color they’d been before, but they’d spread significantly.

“The toxin must react to magic,” Teela said.

“There has to be something we can do,” Adora said, her voice growing frantic.

“He was aiming for you,” Catra said as she retrieved the crystal dagger from where she’d stowed it in her belt. “For She-Ra.”

“That looks like First Ones tech,” Teela said.

“We already know they made weapons designed to kill She-Ra.”

“It was meant for me,” Adora said. Tears welled in her eyes, and she held Catra tighter.

“It’s better this way,” Catra said weakly.

“What are you talking about!?” Adora cried. “Catra, you-”

“Adora, she’s right,” Teela said. “Your whole body is suffused with She-Ra’s magic. If the poison reacted this much to you trying to heal her, there’s no telling how fast it would have spread in you.”

“See, dummy,” Catra forced a chuckle. “Since it hit me, you still have time to save me.”

“That dagger came from Grayskull,” Teela said. “So maybe there’s something there that can fix it: an antidote.”

“Right,” Adora said, her eyes narrowing with resolve. “Gwildor, are we ready to go?”

“No,” said Gwildor despondently. “I’m sorry, but there’s no way back…”

=======

“Our lifelong battle is nearing its end, He-Man,” Skeletor said. “Soon, all the power of Grayskull will be mine for eternity. But before you die, you will have the privilege to witness my ascension and kneel before me.”

“I’ll never kneel to you!” Adam cried, stepping toward Skeletor as far as his chains would allow.

“Yes you will,” Skeletor crowed. “But first…” He nodded to Blade.

Blade walked proudly up to kneel before his master and present him with the Sword of Power. Skeletor took it and slipped the blade into the dock beside the throne. Lights within the crystal pedestal began to pulse rhythmically.

“Sorceress,” Skeletor said, “commence authorization transfer.”

“Of course,” the Sorceress said flatly.

The sword pulsed brighter, and Adam felt a sudden sensation of emptiness that made his breath catch in his throat.

“Transfer complete.”

“Permanently lock all privileges,” Skeletor said.

“Acknowledged.”

“Sorceress,” Adam pleaded, “you don’t have to do this!”

“Foolish boy,” Skeletor mocked. “She is merely a machine, built to serve her masters. As were you, but no longer. You see, control of the Sword has just been permanently reassigned to me.”

“No…”

“Yes,” Skeletor grinned. He sat again on the throne. “But the power granted by the sword is not my objective, merely a means to my ultimate end. Sorceress, begin the priming sequence for the Eye of the Galaxy.”

=======

“What do you mean there’s no way back?” Kevin said.

“Just look at the Key,” Gwildor replied, holding up the scorched and blackened device.

“Skeletor’s lightning…” Teela said.

“He knew exactly what he was doing,” Gwildor said. “If he couldn’t take the Key for himself…”

“Can’t you fix it?” Adora said.

“The power core is melted down,” Gwildor explained, “and its memory is completely erased. Even if I could power it on, the tones are gone.”

“The tones?” Kevin asked.

“You see, Kevin, opening the portal itself isn’t the hard part. The hard part is ensuring it opens in the right place. With the memory

processor wiped, we could search for a thousand lifetimes and never find the tones that would take us back to Eternia."

"Wait, by 'the tones,' do you mean the music the Key played when you'd turn it on? With the big red button?"

"Yes, those are the ones. But without those precise tones, we could wind up in Eternia's sun, or inside a mountain, or in the vacuum of space!"

Kevin started pacing and scratching his head.

"Kevin, what are you thinking?" Teela asked.

"Gwildor," Kevin said, "if we could replicate the right tones somehow, could you get it to work?"

"Theoretically, yes," Gwildor replied. "But even with the ones, there's no way to power it."

"Could we power it with magic?" Adora asked.

"Only if we had some way to convert it into the right kind of energy and bypass the power core."

"What about with a piece of First Ones tech made to react with magic?" Catra said, offering the crystal dagger.

"Well…" Gwildor considered. "It'll be risky, but there's a chance. As long as the tones are precisely correct."

"Define 'precisely,'" Kevin said.

"If the tones are off by even a small amount, without the processor to compensate, we could wind up, well, anywhere."

Kevin started rubbing the back of his head nervously.

"Listen, Kevin," Adora said, "Skeletor has my brother. He has our parents. And Catra…" She paused, blinking back tears. "If there's a chance you can help get us home… Just… please."

“Gwildor,” Teela said, “Kevin knows the tones. Can you get us home or can’t you?”

Gwildor hesitated, everyone looking at him.

“Well…” he said. “Yes, I think so. As long as we have a way to produce the tones, I think I can make it work.”

“Alright then,” Kevin said. “Get started, Gwildor. Charlie, come with me. Hopefully there’s still a working synthesizer in what’s left of your shop.”

“Right,” Charlie said, and together, he and Kevin headed through the door back into the mall.

=======

On dozens of distant, forgotten worlds, ancient machinery hummed to life. Thaumathechnological devices that lay long dormant quickly awaken to fulfill their purpose. On one world, a mountain the locals believed to be haunted split open, a beam of multicolored light blazing off into their night sky. On another, cities panicked as it seemed the whole planet was shaking, and streams of stored magic snaked off into space. Forgotten crystal spires rose from oceans, centuries’ buried hatches yawned open, moons rearranged themselves as the magic in their cores, siphoned and stockpiled for a thousand years by the machines left behind by the First Ones, surged across the galaxy toward its destination.

Countless other worlds observed the unexpected phenomena, unsure what to make of the beams of color-shifting light streaming with unknown purpose across the cosmos. Dozens of streams of unfathomable power converging toward a single point. And on the planet Eternia, at the center of this vast ancient network, a crystal-bladed sword began to glow, and the iris at the pinnacle of Castle Grayskull began to open.

=======

The smoke was white now, thick and billowing. Either the sprinkler system or the firefighters had gotten the blaze under control. Kevin and Charlie's shoes splashed in the water and squelched on the carpet as they entered the remains of the store.

"Oh jeez…" Charlie muttered, surveying the damage.

Kevin, however, focused on the task at hand, looking for a keyboard that hadn't been shot, burned, or drenched. After a few minutes, he found one tucked in the back of a shelf where it looked to have been sheltered from the worst of it. He managed to pull it free and flip the power switch. He ran a finger down the keys and breathed a sigh of relief when he heard the satisfying electronic glissandro.

"Found one," he said. "Let's go."

"Hey hold it," a voice said. "What are you kids doing in here?"

A middle-aged, bald cop was stepping through the thinning smoke, glass crunching beneath his shoes.

"Oh, uh, hey there officer, uh…" Charlie stammered.

"Lubic," the cop said. "Detective Lubic."

"Right, yeah, ok, detective. Listen, this is my shop, this is all my stuff, we're just checking out the damage, y'know?"

"Yeah you can do that once the fire department clears the place," Lubic said. "But for now you need to get out of here until we can sort this all out."

"Charlie," Kevin said impatiently, "we have to get back up there."

"You're not going anywhere unless I say so," said the cop.

There was a brief pause where nobody spoke or moved. Then Kevin tucked the keyboard under his arm and sprinted back out into the mall.

“Hey!” Lubic shouted, drawing his gun. “Stop right now”

Lubic started to chase after Kevin, when Charlie stuck his foot out, tripping the policeman and spilling him face first onto the sopping wet carpet.

“Just what the hell do you think you’re doing?” Lubic spat as he climbed back to his feet.

“Uh…” Charlie said. “Oops?”

=======

Adam stared as the iris high above began to open, and the sword in its pedestal began to glow.

“Yes,” Skeletor mused. “You see, last year when I accessed the memory systems of the traitor Mara’s starship, I learned a great many valuable things. Namely, what befell the Heart of Etheria.”

“Adora destroyed it,” Adam spat. “And she’ll stop you, too!”

“Yes, She-Ra destroyed the Heart. And in so doing, she absorbed all the magic it had collected over a thousand years,” he turned to face Adam. “She held enough raw power in her hands to unmake all of reality with a thought, and she threw it away! As we speak, the magic siphons my people installed on dozens of worlds are beaming their stockpiled magic here. And once I use the sword and I become He-Man, all that power will be mine, forever.”

Adam’s eyes went wide.

“Now you see, don’t you,” Skeletor grinned. “The alpha and the omega. Death and rebirth. And as you die, so shall I be reborn. I, Skeletor, will be master of the universe!”

Skeletor traced a dark sigil in the air before him and cast it skyward. All over the planet, black clouds once again gathered into the likeness of his visage, and his voice boomed across the lands for all to hear.

“People of Eternia,” he began. “I stand within the great Eye of the Galaxy, chosen by destiny to receive the powers of Castle Grayskull. This inevitable moment will transpire before your eyes, even an He-Man himself bears witness to it.”

“The Eye is primed and ready,” said the Sorceress.

Skeletor strode back to the throne, shifted his staff to his left hand, and placed his right on the hilt of the Sword of Power. He locked eyes with Adam, and said…

“By the Power of Grayskull!”

=======

Kevin rushed back out onto the roof. Gwildor was still working on the Key. It was opened and partially disassembled, a tangle of wires strewn about.

“Here,” Kevin said. “I found a keyboard to play the tones on.”

“Excellent!” Gwildor squeaked. “Put it right there, and I’ll get it connected.”

“Just hurry, ok? There’s a cop down there that might follow me up here and get in the way.”

“What’s a cop?” Teela said.

“They’re like… like city guards or something,” Kevin answered. “How’s Catra?”

“Not better,” Adora said, the strain obvious in her voice.

“I’ll be ok,” Catra said weakly, taking Adora’s hand. “I look out for you, and you look out for me.”

“Nothing really bad can happen as long as we have each other,” Adora finished with a sad smile. She leaned down and gently kissed Catra. “I love you.”

“I love you, too,” Catra smiled back.

“Gwildor,” Teela said. “Are we in business?”

“Just one more…” Gwildor said. “There! We just need power and the tones, and we’re off.”

Adora stood and walked over to Kevin, putting a hand on his shoulder.

“You’ve got this,” she said. “I believe in you.”

Kevin nodded, then knelt down in front of the keyboard and switched it on. Adora moved over to where the crystal dagger was wired into the mess of machinery and took hold of it. She raised her other hand above her head, her sword appearing in her grasp.

“For the Honor of Grayskull!” she cried, and with a flash, transformed into She-Ra.

Magic coursed into the dagger, and power surged into the device. The wires began to smoke and spark.

“Now, Kevin, now!” Gwildor cried.

Kevin took a deep breath, and put his hands to the keys. He deliberately pushed aside all anxiety and doubt. His left hand produced the distinct bassy drone while his right played across the “melody” he recalled from earlier that day. The array of silvery forks, placed on the ground in the middle of everyone, expanded and began to spin. Kevin played on as the lights began to flicker and expand.

“It’s working! It’s working!” Gwildor exclaimed.

“You’re doing great, Kevin,” Teela shouted over the din. “Don’t stop!”

Just then, Lubic kicked open the roof access door, gun drawn. But the orders he intended to bark stuck in his throat. He was caught

completely by surprise by the sight before him. There was the kid from downstairs, sitting on the ground playing some weird music on the keyboard he stole. Next to him was what looked like a life-sized Troll doll. And behind them all was an eight-foot tall glowing woman in white holding a sword.

Lubic opened his mouth, trying to speak, to shout orders, anything. But with a brilliant flash of purple light, they all disappeared. Lubic stood alone in the doorway, his gun pointed at empty space. He stood there for several seconds before holstering his weapon and heading back inside.

"I need to retire," he said.

=======

Blinding, multicolored light shot down into Castle Grayskull. Skeletor was completely engulfed in prismatic radiance. Adam had to squeeze his eyes shut and wince away from the overwhelming light and whipping wind. Finally, the light and wind subsided, and everyone gaped at what stood where Skeletor had been.

Towering over nine feet tall, bulging muscle wrapped in dark blue skin, clad in rough black armor that glowed faintly as if heated near red-hot, clawed hands still gripping the staff and sword, and pale green flame seemingly burning within the now horned skull-face. Skeletor stepped forward, gazing down at his new form, energy crackling around his transformed body.

"Yes," his voice thundered within the vaulted chamber. "The power fills me." He held out his free hand. There was a spark, and a miniature sun blazed to life in his palm.

"I am a part of the cosmos," he continued. "Its energy flows through me." He clenched his fist, snuffing out the tiny star, and surveyed the awestruck faces around the room.

"Of what consequence are you now?" he demanded. "This planet, these people, they are nothing to me. The universe is power!" Green lightning flared and crashed all around him. "Pure,

unstoppable power! And I am that force; I am that power!" He stepped further forward still, glaring down at Adam.

"Fool," he hissed. "I am more than man; more than life! I am a god, and you will kneel!"

Skeletor blasted Adam with lightning. The prince staggered back, knees threatening to buckle, but he held his ground. He caught his breath and looked defiantly back at Skeletor.

"I said, KNEEL!!!" Skeletor roared, blasting Adam again.

Again Adam staggered, crying out in pain, sagging almost to the floor, but again he held, refusing to go to his knees. Skeletor appreached, looming over the prince, laughing at him.

"Where is your strength?" he crowed, his voice low for only Adam to hear. "Where are your loyal friends now? Tell me of the loneliness of good, He-Man. Is it equal to the loneliness of evil?"

"I'm not He-Man," Adam said, glaring up into Skeletor's face. "I am Adam, prince of Eternia, protector of the secrets of Castle Grayskull."

Skeletor laughed.

"You don't get it, do you?" Adam said. "You never have. Power carries with it the responsibility to use it on behalf of those with none. To call upon it only when someone else needs it. To protect the innocent and the ones you love. But that's something you'll never understand, and that's why you will always lose!"

"Oh, I'm quite certain that this," Skeletor said, gesturing to himself, "is what 'winning' looks like." The eyes of Skeletor's staff blazed with green light, and he leveled it at Adam. "You are no longer my equal, and now our lifelong battle will at last end in the only way it ever could. Goodbye…Adam."

Suddenly, a thunderous bang echoed through the chamber. Purple light flashed, and a furious wind ripped through the room. A

familiar drone and melody filled the air, sourceless. Then, with a final flash and thunderclap, She-Ra, Teela, Catra, Kevin, and Gwildor appeared a few feet above the outer platform of the chamber. They, along with the mess of wires, debris, and machinery that surrounded them fell to the floor.

“We did it!” Gwildor exclaimed.

Skeletor glared, the green fire in his hollow eyes blazing with rage.

“DESTROY THEM!!!” he roared to his troops.

“Get to cover and stay out of sight,” Adora ordered at Kevin, Catra, and Gwildor. “I’m finishing this!” She leaped across to the central platform, sword raised high, slashing down at Skeletor.

Catra leaned on Kevin as they and Gwildor made their way behind one of the giant statues. Teela ducked behind another, slinging magical blasts at the soldiers and bots that streamed toward them.

Skeletor met Adora’s strike with his staff, blocking it effortlessly.

“Foolish child,” Skeletor growled. “You might have lived had you stayed on that primitive and tasteless planet.”

He pushed Adora back and followed through with a blast of dark magic from his other hand. Adora ducked under the blast and slid to Adam’s side. She quickly sliced through her brother’s shackles.

“Thanks,” he said. “I knew you’d make it back.”

“So how bad is it?” Adora asked, squaring off with Skeletor.

“He stole He-Man’s power and absorbed all the magic of the Eye of the Galaxy,” Adam replied. “So y’know, about as bad as it can get.”

Skeletor roared and unleashed a torrent of green fire at them. Adora turned her sword into a shield to defend, Adam sticking close behind her. Adora's boots began sliding backward from the sheer force of the assault. Skeletor slammed his staff on the floor, a pool of utter darkness spreading out from it. A mass of shadowy tendrils erupted from the blackness and wrapped themselves around Adora, lifting her into the air and then throwing her to the far end of the bridge.

"I'll deal with She-Ra in due time," Skeletor said as the tendrils evaporated. "But I want to destroy you first!"

He rushed at Adam, staff raised over his head to strike. Adam ducked and rolled forward, avoiding the heavy blow that cracked the crystal floor where he'd been standing. He ended in a crouch at the very edge of the central platform. Looking down, he saw the lower level about fifteen feet below. As Skeletor turned and lunged for him again, Adam grabbed the edge of the platform and slid off, dropping to the floor below. The platform and bridge were supported by dozens of thick crystal pillars. Adam slipped between them and out of sight.

Skeletor leaped down after Adam, landing heavily enough to leave a shallow crater. He surveyed the forest of columns that held up the platform above and saw no sign of Adam.

"You cannot hide from me!" Skeletor growled.

Above, Adora climbed back to her feet, recovering from Skeletor's attack. Around her, Beastman, Trapjaw, and Blade approached. Beastman's lip curled back from his fangs as he growled. Trapjaw had a new pincer arm installed. Blade brandished yet another sword. She-Ra raised her sword as well and scowled at them.

"You all sure you still want to do this?" she said. "Because I am done messing around today."

With a yell from Blade, all three struck at once. The Beastman lunged into a low tackle at her legs, Trapjaw grabbed for her

sword-arm, and Blade rushed in, sword aimed up for her throat. She-Ra hopped over Beastman's arms and landed on his shoulders, driving him into the floor. She grabbed Trapjaw's outstretched arm and pivoted, throwing him into Blade.

She stepped off Beastman and kicked him in the side, sending him tumbling across the floor. Trapjaw, still on the floor, grabbed her shin with his claw-arm and yanked her off her feet. Blade sprang back to his feet, leaping at She-Ra with a two-handed overhead strike. Adora barely managed to get her sword into place to block him in time.

Teela was getting tired. After fighting and running for most of the day with little time to rest, her spells were starting to drop in speed and intensity. The outer balcony of the chamber was narrow enough that the bots and soldiers were forced into a bottleneck to approach them, but she was losing ground. With each passing moment, the front line of attackers inched closer and closer.

"I don't know how much longer I can hold them off," Teela called, breathing heavily. "Anyone got any ideas?"

"Yeah, one," Catra said, struggling to her feet. The purple veins had spread down one leg to the knee, down one arm nearly to the elbow, and were creeping up just past her collarbone. "Let the bots through over here."

"You've got to be kidding," Teela said. "You in no-"

"Just do it!" Catra shouted.

With a grumble of frustration, Teela turned and focused her spellfire only on her side of their hiding places. As she did, several bots pushed through toward Catra and Kevin. When the first one got close enough, Catra kicked its legs out from under it and severed its blaster arm with a swift slash of her claws.

"Kevin!" she called, tossing the blaster to him.

Kevin caught the blaster and froze for a moment in surprise. Then he slid his arm into the grip and found the trigger. The first blast nearly knocked him off his feet, but he caught himself against the statue and let loose. Catra retreated behind the statue after smashing two more bots and sank to the floor, breathing heavily and cradling her infected arm.

"That should buy us some time at least," Catra said through gritted teeth. Then under her breath, "C'mon, Adora…"

Adam slipped as quietly as he could from column to column as Skeletor stalked through them. He had no idea what the next move was, but as long as Skeletor was focused on him, it meant Adora and the others were open to do… something. Then Adam started at the sound of shattering crystal.

"You cannot hide forever," Skeletor mocked, smashing through another pillar. "Has the mighty He-Man really become such a coward without his precious sword?"

An idea suddenly sprang to Adam's mind. He found a piece of debris from the smashed pillars on the floor and quickly scooped it up.

"Who's hiding?" Adam declared, stepping out into the open and hurling the chunk of crystal at Skeletor's massive form. It bounced harmlessly off the bulging muscles of his shoulder, but he whirled toward Adam and unleashed a blast of dark magic. Adam dove out of the way as the blast destroyed another pillar and took cover behind another.

"What's wrong, Skeletor?" Adam taunted. "All the power in the universe, and you can't manage to kill one helpless little prince?"

Skeletor roared in fury as he fired blast after blast at Adam, while the prince sprinted, ducked, and rolled to avoid them. Shards of crystal from the destroyed pillars showered them both.

"I could rend you from existence with a thought," Skeletor called. "But I want to crush the life from you with my own hands!"

“Then you have to catch me first!”

Skeletor growled and unleashed a concentrated beam of pale green magic, sweeping across the space and disintegrating a dozen pillars in seconds. The bridge above groaned as the dust and smoke settled. There, in the open, stood Adam. Skeletor raised his staff and grinned.

“I tire of this game,” he said. “I suppose I’ll settle for watching you turn to dust!”

“I want to thank you first,” Adam said.

“What?”

“For the escape route.”

Above them, the groaning of the crystal bridge intensified. The bridge cracked, Skeletor having destroyed too many of its supports, and fell between them forming both a barrier and a ramp back up to the central platform. Without hesitation, Adam sprinted up the ramp, eyes locked on the pedestal beside the throne. Even without its power, the sword was still a sword.

Adora shoved Blade off to the side and rolled back to her feet only to feel Trapjaw’s claw clamp down around her waist. She tried to swing her sword back at him, but the angle was wrong. Then Beastman grabbed her sword arm and twisted it back, robbing her of the leverage to swing it. She let the sword vanish from that hand and conjured it back in the other, just in time for black tendrils of magic to wrap around that arm too. She looked to see Evil-Lyn standing in the doorway to the chamber, staff aglow, with a wicked smile on her face.

“Finish it, Blade,” Evil-Lyn said.

“With pleasure,” Blade replied, producing another crystal dagger from his belt.

Adam reached the top of the ramp and raced for the sword. He could see the terrified faces of his parents in their prison, but had to shut that out at the moment. He reached the pedestal and grasped the sword's handle. He tried to pull it free, but it slid up only a few inches. It was a very tight fit. Nonetheless, Adam kept pulling with all his might, managing to slip it another inch out.

Skeletor leaped up from below, landing heavily on the platform. He spotted Adam and stalked toward him, towering over him.

"That powerless little toy will do you no good now, boy," he growled.

Adam frantically pulled harder, feeling the blade slip another inch. Skeletor closed the distance between them and swung one massive fist at his midsection. The breath was knocked out of Adam immediately. Before he had time to process if that cracking sound he'd heard had been his ribs, he impacted the wall. Skeletor had punched him with enough force to hurl him from the platform to the outer wall.

Adam slid to the floor, vision tunneling, ears ringing, unable to breath. Finally, he managed to painfully suck in a lungful of air, gasping and choking. As his mind unfogged, he could feel a stabbing pain in his chest and a throbbing ache in the back of his head. He registered a metallic taste in his mouth. But most importantly, he felt the familiar hilt of the Sword of Power still in his hand.

He struggled to his feet, leaning against the wall, and lifted the sword…

Only to see that the crystal blade had been snapped off six inches from the guard.

Adam's heart sank. He let the broken sword fall from his grasp as he looked around the chamber. He saw Skeletor in front of the throne, head thrown back laughing. Behind him, his mother and father, trapped. On the far side of the chamber, Teela and Kevin

trying their best to hold back the onslaught of soldiers and bots, Catra and Gwildor crouched in cover. He saw Adora, held down by Beastman, Trapjaw, and Evil-Lyn. He saw Blade moving slowly toward her with a crystal dagger.

No. It couldn't end this way. He had to save them. That desperate need to protect the ones he loved burned in his chest like a bonfire; felt like electricity buzzing within his bones. He stepped away from the wall, unsteady on his feet, but feeling that fiery electric sensation welling up as if looking for a way out, like he might burst otherwise. It brought with it a clarity of purpose and action. His right arm rose above his head as if on its own will, that burning tingle racing up to his fingertips.

And when the words came, they felt inevitable…

"FOR THE HONOR OF GRAYSKULL!!!"

Lightning struck through the still open iris of the Eye, and Adam caught it in his outstretched hand. He was engulfed in a swirling column of multicolored light. Everyone stared in wide-eyed disbelief as the spectacle unfolded. From within the blinding magical maelstrom, Adam's voice called out again, booming, echoing in the vaulted chamber.

"I HAVE THE POWER!"

The swirling light and wind finally subsided, and where Adam had been standing, somehow, was He-Man. A gleaming gold harness crossed his bare chest, and he had matching golden bracers on his wrists. White pants tucked into gold-trimmed boots not unlike his sister's. And in his hand, a gleaming silver sword, the crossguard curled up toward the glowing blade. His whole body glowed with rainbow-shifting light, his mop of hair fluttering in a sourceless breeze.

"Impossible…" Skeletor breathed. "The power should be mine and mine alone. How did it answer your call? What are you!?"

In an instant, He-Man leapt and closed distance with Skeletor, the latter barely managing to bring his staff up to block his sword in time. Skeletor pushed him aside, his surprise giving way to rage.

“How I long to rend you from existence,” Skeletor fumed. “To wipe your accursed face from my memory. No longer will you stand between me and my destiny!”

“But I will,” Adam said. “This has always been between us.”

“Indeed,” Skeletor said. “Then let this be our final battle!”

As their weapons clashed between them in a shower of sparks and crackling energy, the other occupants of the chamber broke their attention from the spectacle. The bots resumed their advance on Catra, Teela, Kevin, and Gwildor’s position. Blade turned the crystal dagger again toward She-Ra. And She-Ra again struggled to break free.

Then another flash of light lit up the chamber, this one bright pink. And a familiar voice cried out…

Catra saw the new arrivals, and a wide grin spread on her face in spite of the pain.

“Oh you guys are in for it now,” she said.

“Now, Hordak!” Glimmer shouted. She’d teleported into the control chamber along with Bow, Scorpia, Hordak, Micah, and Duncan.

Hordak was in his battle armor for the first time since the fall of Prime, and he held a boxy contraption covered in lights, wires, and antennae tucked between his chest and arm cannon. He grasped a handle on the box and twisted it.

There was a deep buzzing hum, and the air rippled. Then, all around the chamber and beyond, Skeletor's bots began spewing sparks from every joint and crumpled to the ground.

"It worked!" Bow laughed. Then he gasped. "Adora!" he cried. “Hold on!”

Bow nocked and fired an arrow at Beastman, which burst open and splattered his face with sticky green goo. Beastman clutched at his face, trying to scrape the glue off, but only got his hand stuck. He released She-Ra’s arm to try to free his other hand, but it got stuck, too. He fell to the floor, snarls muffled by the thick adhesive, both hands stuck to his own head.

Her arm free, Adora conjured her sword and blasted Blade away, the crystal dagger flying out of his hand. Before she could move to throw off the other fighters holding her, Scorpia rushed over and clamped down on Trapjaw’s claw with her own pincers, forcing him to release Adora.

“Pick on somebody your own claws,” she said. “Or – I mean – ah forget it.”

That left Evil-Lyn. Micah stepped next to Adora and cast a quick spell to sever the dark tendrils.

“Go help your brother,” Micah said. “I’ll handle her.”

Adora nodded, then sprinted off toward the broken edge of the bridge, leaping across to where Adam and Skeletor were fighting.

“Another sorcerer,” Evil-Lyn taunted. “This might actually be fun.”

“You and your boss wrecked my daughter’s wedding reception,” Micah said coolly as he traced sigils in the air. “That was a poor choice.”

As Micah and Evil-Lyn began their spellcasters’ duel, Duncan ran toward where Blade was recovering from She-Ra’s blast. He swung his heavy mace down at Blade with both hands, but the other man managed to roll aside. Blade kipped up to his feet and drew a pair of short swords.

“Let’s go, old man,” Blade taunted.

Back over by the statues, Kevin tried to fire his blaster again, but nothing happened.

“Uh guys,” he said, “I think this thing just ran out of juice!”

Teela, sweating and breathing hard, cast a spell at another soldier, but the blast just glanced off the armor. She was spent. As the soldiers closed in on them, there was another pink flash, and Glimmer appeared in their midst, glancing quickly to either side. She let off heavy blasts in both directions, sending several soldiers flying and the rest scattering.

“Nice timing, Sparkles,” Catra said, her voice strained.

“Catra, you’re hurt!” Glimmer said, crouching down beside her. The purple veins were halfway up her neck and had spread across her chest to start making their way down the other arm.

“We’ve got bigger problems right now,” Catra said. “Go help the others. We’re clear here now.”

“But-”

“Just finish it quick,” Catra interrupted, “so we have time to find the antidote.”

Glimmer nodded, and teleported away in another flash of pink. Kevin stared wide-eyed at the interaction.

"Yes, my best friend can teleport and do magic," Catra said impatiently. "This is not the weirdest thing you've seen today."

Chaos reigned in the secret chamber of Castle Grayskull. Duncan dueled with Blade, Bow providing ranged support. Scorpia grappled with Trapjaw, his mechanical augmentation not quite a match for her pincers. Micah and Evil-Lyn traded blasts of spells on the stairs leading from the chamber, Glimmer appearing behind her to pin her down. Hordak stood at the end of the bridge, keeping what soldiers remained at bay with his arm cannon. And

on the central platform, Skeletor was locked in fierce battle with He-Man and She-Ra.

One of Bow's arrows opened into a bolas, wrapping around Blade and pinning his arms to his side. Duncan then landed a heavy blow to his abdomen with his mace. Blade crumpled to the floor and did not get back up.

Glimmer teleported all around Evil-Lyn, peppering her with blasts from every unexpected angle.

"Annoying gnat!" Evil-Lyn cried, trying and failing to anticipate her erratic movements.

Micah finished weaving the spell he'd been setting up while Glimmer kept Evil-Lyn's attention, and he sprung the trap. Tendrils of sticky blue goop rose up around her and lashed inward, wrapping her up and holding her immobile. Glimmer appeared again in front of her.

"That's 'Her Royal Highness Annoying Gnat' to you," Glimmer teased, giving her father a high-five.

Scorpia's pincers crunched into the metal of Trapjaw's mechanical arm, its claw twitching spasmodically. He glared at her through the openings of his jaggedly spiked helmet. She smiled back.

"This has been fun," said Scorpia, "but I think we're done now."

With that, she hoisted a surprised Trapjaw effortlessly over her head. He struggled and flailed in her grip. Scorpia's tail whipped forward lightning fast, and every muscle in Trapjaw's body tensed at once. She dropped him spasming on the floor.

On the central platform, Adam and Adora fought Skeletor in perfect tandem. Adam blocked a strike from Skeletor's staff, and Adora slashed at his leg. She rolled away from the counterattack, opening Adam up to wound his shoulder. Together, they swung heavy overhead strikes, and Skeletor blocked them both at once with his staff. The twins nodded to each other, each taking one

hand off their swords, and punched Skeletor hard in the gut. He flew back from the blow, cracking the crystal throne as he fell.

"You're outmatched Skeletor," Adora said.

"It's over," Adam added.

"Yes…" Skeletor hissed as he pulled himself free of the shattered throne and climbed to his feet. "Over for you!"

Skeletor unleashed a ferocious onslaught of magical energy, green lightning and purple-black tendrils lashing viciously at them both. He-Man and She-Ra raised their swords and managed to just barely block the attack, their feet sliding back almost to the edge of the platform.

Adora leaned forward, pushing back against that blast, managing to take a single step forward. Adam pushed forward too, gaining them both another step.

"I WILL DESTROY YOU ALL!" Skeletor shrieked, waves of darkness flowing off him as he continued the assault.

In a flash of pink, Glimmer and Micah appeared next to She-Ra and He-Man, each quickly tracing sigils in the air and unleashing their own blasts of magic. From the outer rim of the chamber, Bow launched arrow after arrow, Duncan fired his blaster, and Hordak his arm cannon. Scorpia rushed up the broken bridge to join the others, adding her own red lightning to the mix.

Kevin, Teela, Catra, and Gwildor watched all this unfold in shocked awe.

“No!” Skeletor growled. “I cannot be defeated by the likes of you! Sorceress, engage the Eye! Give me more!”

“Exceeding projected parameters not recommended,” the Sorceress’s voice said flatly.

“Override!” Skeletor roared. “Give me everything!”

The whole castle suddenly lurched, nearly throwing Kevin off balance. He felt a low rumble through his feet that grew steadily and rapidly more intense. Light began to shine through the open iris in the ceiling. Then, with an ear-splitting crack, a deep fissure suddenly snaked its way up the wall beside them. A chunk of the blue-pink crystal broke free and fell. Kevin grabbed Catra's arm and quickly dragged her out from under it, Gwildor and Teela diving aside as well, before the massive hunk of debris smashed into and through the floor. The shaking grew even more intense.

"He's going to bring this whole place down!" Catra cried.

"We have to do something," Kevin said.

"What can we do?" said Gwildor.

It was then that Kevin spotted a glint of light, something on the floor reflecting the blinding mass of clashing light in the center of the room. A thin sliver of purple crystal.

"Teela," he said, "can you get me to the platform?"

Kevin snatched up the crystal dagger and raced to the edge.

"Fast as you can," Teela warned. "I won't be able to hold it for long." She raised her arm, and with great effort conjured a thin, shimmering bridge of light.

Kevin sprinted across as fast as his legs would carry him. Twenty feet. Twelve. Six. The bridge began to flicker, Teela crying out with exertion trying to hold it in place. Kevin jumped with everything he had just as the surface vanished from beneath his feet. He didn't make the distance, his chest impacting the side of the platform, and he held on for dear life.

Another beam of rainbow light lanced through the iris and into Skeletor. The castle shook harder, statues toppling, slabs of crystal cracking and falling from the walls and ceiling. With the additional rush of power, Skeletor increased the ferocity of his attack, his enemies pushed back, losing ground. He laughed triumphantly,

victory finally in his grasp, when he felt something touch his leg. He glanced down reflexively to discover its source.

Skeletor saw the earthling boy, eyes squinting against the light and rushing wind, fists clenched together and pressed to Skeletor's thigh. With a swipe of his hand, he effortlessly batted the boy aside, sending him sprawling almost over the edge of the platform. And then he saw it.

He saw the thin shard of crystal jabbed into his skin.

"No…"

Bright glowing purple veins spiderwebbed out from the wound, streaking over his entire body almost instantly. They glowed brighter and brighter, spread faster and faster.

"NOW!" Adam cried.

They dug deep, pouring every bit of strength they had at Skeletor. His pained and furious screams were drowned by the overwhelming onslaught. And when their combined blasts finally subsided, the castle stopped shaking. When the smoke and dust cleared, they saw only the cracked sword pedestal and the shattered crystal throne.

Skeletor was no more.

Chapter End Notes

> Ok so I lied. This chapter was way longer than I anticipated, so I'll be wrapping everything up in an epilogue chapter soon. Thanks again for coming along with me on this ride.

# Epilogue

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Fireworks lit up the skies over Erternos. The work to rebuild what had been demolished by Skeletor's final attack would be difficult and would take a long time. But tonight was for celebration. After generations of living under constant threat from Snake Mountain, it was finally over.

Eternia was finally safe.

Adam could hear the distant sounds of music and laughter in the city below as he sat alone on a parapet of the palace.

"Hey Adam," Adora's voice called.

He looked over his shoulder to see the tired but smiling face of his sister approaching. He returned the smile.

"Mind if I join you?" she asked. "Or did you want to be alone?"

Adam gestured to the space beside him, and Adora sat down. The twins sat there for a long while in silence, dangling their feet off the roof's edge and watching the colorful lights of celebration above and below.

"How's Catra?" Adam asked at length.

"She's good," Adora replied. "Resting, but good."

"That's a relief," Adam said. "If I'd known she was hurt when-"

"Don't," Adora interrupted. "If you start playing through all the 'what-ifs' and 'should haves' you'll drive yourself crazy. Believe me, I know."

"Right…"

"We're just lucky Hordak was able to counteract the poison so fast."

"Yeah, how did he do that?"

"He and Entrapta had been working on a counter to that red virus crystal stuff. Turns out the purple ones work similarly enough that it just had to be modified a little."

"Oh I hate that stuff," Adam said. He paused. "Do you think it would even work on me anymore? Or would I be immune to it now like you are?"

"I don't really know," Adora replied. "And I don't exactly want to go looking for any of it again to find out."

Adam nodded, then fell silent again.

"It doesn't feel real," he said after a few minutes. "This all being over, I mean."

"Yeah, I definitely know that feeling," Adora said.

"He's really gone," Adam whispered. "I'm not sure I even know what to do with myself now."

"That's just it," Adora said, putting her hand on his. "You do whatever you want, whatever makes you happy."

"Not sure I even know what that is anymore."

"It'll take time to get used to not being in a war anymore," Adora said. "But you will. It gets easier every day."

Adam smiled and leaned over to give his sister a hug.

"So Kevin," Adora said after they parted. "He's going to be stuck here on Eternia for a little while until Gwildor can build another Key to send him back to Earth."

"Is that so," Adam said, his cheeks flushing slightly.

“Oh come on,” she teased, pushing her shoulder into his. “I mean we all saw you.”

Adam’s face turned redder, recalling the moments after Skeletor was destroyed.

Glimmer had teleported Adora and Hordak over to Catra to check on her, and Adam had changed back to himself to rush over and check on Kevin.
“Kevin!” he’d cried. “Are you alright?”

“I think so,” Kevin had said. “Man, that hurt…” He rubbed his chest where Skeletor had struck him.

“That was incredibly brave and incredibly stupid,” Adam had said, taking Kevin’s hand and  helping him to his feet. “You’re amazing. Thank you.”

“Well, you know,” Kevin had said, blushing and rubbing the back of his head. “It’s not every day you get the chance to help save the universe from a crazy skull-faced alien wizard.”

Adam was still holding onto Kevin’s hand.

“I uh,” he stammered. “I kind of really want to k-”

Kevin threw his arms around Adam’s shoulders and kissed him. Adam was surprised at first, but put his arms around Kevin and returned it.

Adam smiled as he recalled the moment. In the hours since then, things had been very busy. Freeing his parents from the force field, bringing Entrapta to Eternia so she and Hordak could cure Catra’s poison, finding somewhere to lock up Skeletor’s captured minions until they had time to figure out what to do with them. Word of Skeletor’s demise had spread quickly though, and the celebration of the war’s end had erupted not just in Eternos, but everywhere. Many friends from Etheria had come through to join the celebrations as well.

After a while, the party and all the people had gotten to be too much, so Adam had slipped quietly away to be alone. He was exhausted, but he still had too much to process to be able to fall asleep. So he'd made his way up to this parapet to sit and contemplate everything that had transpired.

"There's one thing I still don't understand," Adam said at last.

"What's that?" Adora asked.

"How am I still able to turn into He-Man?" he said. "I mean, it makes sense that *you* could after you destroyed your old sword. She-Ra was part of Etheria long before our ancestors came along and bound her to it. But He-Man was just a copy. He didn't exist at all without the sword. So…how?"

"Yeah there was some talk about that earlier," Adora said. "Bow thinks maybe the First Ones made a better copy of She-Ra than even they realized. Entrapta and Hordak think maybe the power surge from the Eye somehow created a duplicate version that attached himself to you. But I don't think either of those are what really happened."

"Well, what do you think it was?" Adam asked. "How do you think he came back?"

"I think it was you," she said.

"Me?"

"Yeah. Your compassion, your kindness, your courage," she smiled and shrugged. "Your heart. Whatever He-Man was, what he was made to be, *you* changed him. You made him more than that."

Adam smiled and leaned into Adora's shoulder.

"I love you, sis," he said.

"I love you, too."

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A few days later, Catra had fully recovered from the First Ones' toxin, and she and Adora were ready to go home to Etheria. After many long goodbyes with Adora's family, they opened the portal beacon and stepped through.

"Are you sure you're feeling ok?" Adora asked as they returned to their room in the palace at Brightmoon.

"I'm fine, Adora," Catra said. "I promise. Still, after all that, I just want to lay around for a couple days and do absolutely nothing."

"I think we can make that happen," Adora said, smiling.

They flopped into their bed and let out a simultaneous sigh. It was good to be home. They lay there for a few minutes, holding hands and staring off at nothing in particular. Eventually, Catra broke the silence.

"Hey Adora?" she said.

"Yeah?" Adora replied.

"...Marry me."

"What?" Adora said, sitting up and looking down at her.

"I don't know why I was so freaked out by the idea a few days ago," Catra said. "But I've never been more sure of anything."

"Catra…"

"I just… Look, the next time some thousand-year-old alien psycho tries to destroy the universe, and we rush off to stop him, I want to be fighting side-by-side with my wife."

Adora leaned down and kissed Catra, although her ear-to-ear smile made it a little difficult.

"Of course I'll marry you, dummy," Adora whispered.

“Hey,” Catra chuckled, “that’s my line.”

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The couple of weeks Kevin spent on Eternia were, despite getting caught up in the middle of an interstellar war and having to guide a cosmic portal across the universe with nothing but an old keyboard, some of the most peaceful times of his life. And he was grateful for the time he got to spend with Adam while they waited for Gwildor to build a new Cosmic Key.

He was surprised how quickly he was able to let his guard down. Nobody gawked or stared or muttered hateful things under their breath when they saw him and Adam walking along hand in hand or caught them sharing a kiss. He realized that he could really get used to this place, and that’s exactly why he knew he had to go home to Earth. And when the day came, all that was left was to say goodbye.

“Do you really have to go?” Adam asked.

They stood in a courtyard of the palace, hands clasped together, foreheads touching.

“I do,” Kevin said. “As much as I love it here, and as much as I care about you, I do have to go back.”

They stood in silence, holding each other. After a few minutes, Kevin spoke again.

“I haven’t told you about Julien,” he said.

Adam shook his head.

“Julien was my first boyfriend,” Kevin explained. “First serious one anyway. And with the way things are on my world… Well, he wanted to stand up to it. He wanted us to be seen, together, unashamed and unafraid.”

Kevin swallowed hard.

"But I *was* afraid," he continued. "I was afraid of how we'd be seen, how we'd be treated. That someone would hurt us… And that ended up tearing us apart. He left to go fight the good fight, and I stayed in our hometown and… hid."

Kevin looked up into Adam's eyes.

"But I'm not afraid anymore," he said. "You and your friends helped me find my courage. And you showed me a world that I don't even think I believed was possible. A world the way it should be. Where people like me are treated as we are: *normal.* So I have to go back. I have to go back and fight for that, fight to make my world the way it should be."

He leaned in and kissed Adam on the cheek.

"And I never would have found the courage for that if not for you," he said. "So thank you."

Adam sniffed and wiped tears from his eyes.

"I want to come visit you," Adam said. "Do you think that would be alright?"

"Of course!" Kevin replied. "And I want you to bring Adora and Catra and Teela along too. I promise there are way more fun things to do on Earth besides getting shot at by aliens and robots."

They both laughed.

"It's goodbye for now," Kevin said. "Not forever."

Adam nodded. He leaned in for one more kiss before Kevin stepped away toward the center of the courtyard.

"Alright Gwildor," Kevin said. "I'm ready."

"Have a good journey, Kevin," Gwildor said. "I look forward to our next meeting."

“Same here,” Kevin said.

Gwildor pressed the energizer switch on the new Key, and the familiar drone filled the air. A swirling purple vortex materialized in the air in front of Kevin. He looked back and waved at Adam as he stepped through. A few moments later the portal closed as he arrived back in his apartment on Earth, a few loose papers drifting back to the floor after being scattered by the wind from the portal.

After standing alone in the silence for a minute, Kevin took a breath, pulled a suitcase from his closet, and started to pack. There was a lot to do to join the fight to make his world a better one. But he believed now, both that a better world was possible and in his own ability to help make it a reality.

To make a world where they wouldn’t have to fight anymore.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you all so much for coming on this journey with me. Took us awhile, but we finally got there. And especially thanks for coming back to this story after such a long hiatus.

I have more plans for other stories in the future. Maybe a few more She-Ra/He-Man shorts, but nothing as big as these. Probably. I'm also thinking about a Critical Role/Mighty Nein story. That idea is sill baking though.

I'll leave you, dear reader, with this image:
A year later, Adam, Adora, Catra, Bow, and Glimmer visit Kevin on Earth and go with him to a Pride parade.

Thanks again for reading. So long.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!